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LIC/P/1/2024-25/51/Eng

IDFC First Bank flags ₹590 cr fraud at Chandigarh branch

UNDER LENS. Issue tied to Haryana govt-linked accounts; four bank officials suspended

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

IDFC First Bank on Sunday informed that it has identified a potential fraud amounting to ₹590 crore emerging from its Chandigarh branch, according to an exchange filing.

The matter is confined to a specific group of Haryana government-linked accounts operated through the said branch in Chandigarh and does not extend to other customers of the branch, it said.

The fraud amount is higher than the ₹503 crore net profit that the lender posted in Q3FY26.

The lender recently received a request from a department of the Haryana government for closure of its account and transfer of funds to another bank. In the process, the bank observed a certain discrepancy in the amount mentioned as against the balance in the account.

From February 18 onwards, certain other Haryana government entities engaged with the lender with regard to their respective accounts and during the process, differences were observed between the balances in the account and the balances as mentioned by the said Haryana government entities holding



DISCREPANCY FOUND. The bank received a request from a Haryana government department to close its account and transfer the funds, during which it noticed a mismatch

accounts with the bank.

“The aggregate amount under reconciliation across the identified accounts at the above mentioned branch is approximately ₹590 crore. The impact may be determined based on receipt of further information, validation of claims, recoveries of any nature, including those made through the process of marking lien on fraudulent beneficiary accounts maintained with other banks, liabilities of other entities involved in the fraudulent transactions and the legal recovery process,” the notice said.

CORRECTIVE STEPS

IDFC First Bank said it had placed four suspected officials under suspension till investigation into the matter concludes.

A meeting of the special committee of the Board for monitoring and follow-up

of cases of frauds (SCBMF) was convened on February 20, 2026, and the matter was placed before the committee.

Further, the meeting of the Audit Committee and the Board of Directors was convened on February 21, 2026, and the lender is now in the process of appointing an external agency to conduct an independent forensic audit.

“The statutory auditors have been informed. The bank has filed a complaint with the police authorities and will extend full cooperation to the investigating agencies. The bank has sent recall request to certain beneficiary banks to lien mark balance in suspicious accounts held in these banks,” it said.

GOVT'S ACTION

The Haryana government, meanwhile, has de-emphasised IDFC First Bank and

AU Small Finance Bank from government business in the State with immediate effect till further orders.

It said no government funds shall henceforth be parked, deposited, invested or transacted through these banks, advising all concerned State government departments to take immediate action for transfer of balances and closure of accounts maintained with the above banks.

The State's Finance Ministry said certain banks were not adhering to the conditions under which fixed deposits are being made by the departments and corporations.

DEPOSIT NORMS

In several cases, it was observed that despite clear instructions to place the funds in flexible deposits or fixed deposit instruments offering higher rates of interest, the banks were retaining the funds in savings accounts, resulting in lower returns.

The Ministry mandated all departments to ensure that fixed deposits are placed strictly in accordance with the approved terms and conditions. Regular verification must be done to confirm that the banks are complying with the deposit instructions.

Govt will release new GDP series on February 27, Q3 growth likely at 7.2%

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The government will release GDP data based on the revised 2022-23 base year on February 27, with markets closely tracking growth for the October-December quarter (Q3 FY26).

However, the new series, which incorporates significant data and methodological changes, has made forecasters wary of firm projections.

Rating agency ICRA has pegged Q3 growth at 7.2 per cent, moderating from 8.2 per cent in the July-September quarter. Several other economists declined to offer estimates, citing uncertainty around the recalibrated dataset.

In December, the Monetary Policy Committee of

the Reserve Bank of India had projected real GDP growth for the third quarter at 7 per cent.

DATA CHALLENGE

Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ICRA, said estimating GDP under the new base year framework remains challenging.

“We have anchored the outlook for Q3 to the existing GDP dataset across sectors of the economy, based on which we project GDP growth to have eased to 7.2 per cent in Q3 2025-26 from 8 per cent in the first half of the fiscal,” she said.

She attributed the sequential slowdown to an unfavourable base effect, contraction in Central government capital expenditure, subdued State government revenue spending and weak merchandise exports. However, she noted



that “healthy demand during the festive season, boosted by GST rationalisation, likely kept the pace of growth above 7 per cent in the said quarter.”

Devendra Kumar Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings & Research, refrained from giving a growth estimate but said nominal GDP could see an upward revision due to changes in item weights under the new series.

He cited the example of mobile handsets and television sets. In the 2011-12

series, feature phones had a higher weight relative to smartphones.

THE DISTORTION

“If I compare, say 2011-12 to 2023-24, the feature phone may give me a negative growth rate. Whereas your smartphone, which has a smaller weight, has grown disproportionately very high. The smartphone growth was not captured in 2011-12, whereas the negative growth of feature phone is being captured,” he said.

A similar distortion existed between CRT television sets and newer technologies such as plasma, LCD and LED TVs, which will now be corrected.

“All these mean the size of the economy is likely to be much higher than what we were estimating,” Pant said.

From matting wickets to Ranji final — J&K's historic rise in cricket

The State where the fabled Kashmir willow comes from will take on Karnataka tomorrow

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

On Tuesday, the Ranji Trophy cricket finals being played in Hubballi will feature a first — pitted against the star-studded Karnataka team will be a relative minnow Jammu & Kashmir. The J&K team, led by seasoned campaigner Paras Dogra, scripted history last week when it defeated Bengal to set up the title clash against Karnataka.

Cricket commentators are hailing it as a powerful moment of transformation for the State as the spotlight turns on the raw talent of bowlers like Aaqib Nabi.

Overcoming Bengal by six wickets was no mean feat for a side that has long battled inadequate infrastructure, limited coaching facilities and a shortage of turf wickets at many of its home venues.

In the absence of advanced facilities, players honed their skills on ordinary grounds and matting wickets in small



The J&K team scripted history last week when it defeated Bengal to set up the title clash against Karnataka

towns and villages across the region, rather ironic when you consider the fabled Kashmiri willow was the very first bat of little master Sachin Tendulkar.

“It is a huge achievement for a team that has long operated without adequate professional cricketering infrastructure,” said Parvez Rasool, the first cricketer from Jammu and Kashmir to represent India in ODIs and T20Is.

He said that although some infrastructure has been developed in recent years, the region was earlier almost entirely devoid of professional training facilities, quality turf wickets and struc-

tured coaching systems.

Jammu and Kashmir's key sports facilities include the Sher-e-Kashmir Cricket Stadium and the Maulana Azad Stadium, with the Srinagar stadium having hosted two One-Day Internationals in 1983 and 1986.

WEAK LINKS

Waheed ur Rehman Parra, Pulwama MLA and former secretary of the Jammu and Kashmir Sports Council, said the Union Territory must prioritise long-term investment in its sporting ecosystem. “J&K needs to invest seriously in both infrastructure and coaching, as both remain weak

links in our sports ecosystem. We require more stadiums, better training facilities, proper incentives for coaches, and the establishment of dedicated sports academies,” Parra said.

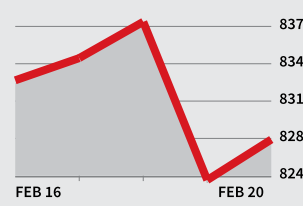
“The focus should shift from merely hosting events to building long-term sporting capacity and nurturing talent at the grassroots level,” he added.

Last month, Sports Minister Satish Sharma said the government is working to establish world-class sports facilities, including modern cricket stadiums, in the twin capital cities. He added that the focus extends beyond infrastructure development to nurturing youth talent, discipline and confidence.

During the ongoing Budget session, the government informed the Assembly that ₹137 crore had been released for up-grading sports across J&K. A win in the Ranji finals could well provide a much-needed boost.

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 82814.71 (+187.95)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	25571.25	+100.15
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.74	+0.05
US Dollar (in ₹)	90.98	+0.35
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	154445.00	+2292
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	250314.00	+7881

BRANDLINE.

Geographical and technological volatility is driving a shorter-term focus on spending, says ad veteran Sir Martin Sorrell **p6**



PULSE.

Concerns grow as digital addiction strains mental wellbeing and cognitive development **p9**

MONDAY SPECIALS.

QUANTUM

How sea microbes can protect agri fields



Today, agriculture faces pressure from soil degradation and the climate crisis. Our oceans can serve as a large laboratory for solutions to help plants withstand such stresses. Marine biotechnology has the potential to disrupt the fertilizer and pesticide markets. Prof Radhakrishnan Manikkam of the Centre for Drug Discovery and Development at Sathyabama Institute of Science and Technology says marine microbes hold promise in agricultural biotech. **p7**

LOGISTICS

'Green' growth on inland waterways

Aimed at accelerating green mobility, the Inland Waterways Development Council has unveiled a roadmap to expand the inland water transport network, facilitate major infrastructure investments and enhance Centre-State coordination to unlock the full economic potential of domestic river systems. **p8**

SEBI board meet on Mar 23 may review conflict of interest rules

ON THE AGENDA. Proposals on netting of funds for foreign portfolio investor transactions, fit and proper norms for intermediaries likely to be taken up

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai



WHAT'S IN STORE? The SEBI board is expected to consider around 20 items for discussion REUTERS

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) board meeting scheduled for March 23 is expected to discuss the conflict of interest framework for senior officials again, along with likely proposals on netting of funds for foreign portfolio investor (FPI) transactions, revisions to 'fit and proper person' norms for intermediaries, and changes in trading at stock exchanges, among others, according to people familiar with the matter.

The final agenda for the meeting has not yet been finalised. However, the board is expected to consider around 20 items, including proposals not placed at the previous board meeting on December 17.

KEY ISSUE

One of the key issues expected to be discussed is the conflict of interest and disclosure framework for SEBI's senior officials, based on the recommendations of a high-level committee report. The board had deferred

a decision on the framework to be formalised in the December meeting, saying more deliberation was needed. "The conflict of interest report is expected to be discussed again, but it remains a discussion item for now," said a person aware of the matter. "The board reaching a conclusion soon looks difficult."

The board may consider a proposal to permit netting of funds for transactions undertaken by FPIs. The proposal seeks to allow offsetting of pay-in and pay-out obligations across trades, a move that could ease liquidity management and lower operational costs for overseas investors. "This is something FPIs have been

seeking for some time, but the regulator will look closely at settlement and risk implications," said another source.

The meeting may also discuss amendments to the 'fit and proper person' criteria for intermediaries. The proposal aims to tighten and clarify eligibility and integrity standards for intermediaries by refining disclosure and assessment parameters to remove ambiguity around suitability norms.

Another proposal that may be taken up is modification of master circulars for stock exchanges and clearing corporations and the commodity derivatives segment. The amendments aim to improve the ease-of-doing-busi-

ness and compliance at stock exchanges by simplifying regulatory requirements and removing redundant provisions and duplication. These include merging, demerging and removing provisions.

An email sent to SEBI did not elicit a response until press time.

PRICE BANDS

Other proposals that may come up for discussion include changes to base price and price band provisions for exchange traded funds to improve price discovery, relaxations in reporting requirements for stockbrokers as part of ease of doing-business measures, and extension of standing instructions for systematic withdrawal and transfer plans for mutual fund units held in dematerialised form.

The board may take stock of proposals aimed at easing regulatory processes for RE-ITs and InvITs, providing flexibility to alternative investment funds in winding up schemes or surrendering registration, reviewing stress-testing norms and settlement guarantee fund coverage in the commodity derivatives segment.

India pauses trade team's visit, will assess US SC tariff ruling

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



The Indian team was scheduled to visit the US from February 23 to 25

The Indian team negotiating the trade deal with the US has postponed its scheduled visit to Washington following the US Supreme Court's decision on Friday invalidating reciprocal tariffs imposed on partner countries, official sources said.

While exporters say that they can absorb the 15 per cent global tariffs imposed by US President Donald Trump as long as no new tariffs are added, experts suggest that India should now pause negotiations or carefully recalibrate its position in light of the ruling.

"The two sides are of the view that the proposed visit of the Indian chief negotiator and the team be scheduled after each side has had the time to evaluate the latest developments and its implications. The meeting will be rescheduled at a mutually convenient date," sources in the Commerce Department said.

US VISIT

The Indian team was scheduled to visit Washington on February 23-25 to finalise the legal text for the interim trade pact, the framework for which was agreed to by

to walk out of the ongoing negotiations, he added.

India's decision to not send its negotiating team right away is a welcome decision and India should carefully re-calibrate its position, said Abhijit Das, independent trade expert and former head of the Centre for WTO Studies.

SOME RELIEF

Most Indian exporters of labour-intensive goods are relieved by the lowering of additional duties but are concerned about Trump's warning on duties under other heads in the future.

"After the duty correction from 50 to 18 per cent/25 per cent the prospects for India have improved again. Now with the 15 per cent global tariffs, it's on par with any nation. We just have to be sure that India does not get any further tariffs under the 301 or 201 Sections. Earlier closure of the bilateral trade agreement will help in this regard," said Israr Ahmed, a Chennai-based exporter of leather goods.

Garments exporter Sanjay Jain said the 15 per cent tariffs after the US Supreme Court's judgment are almost at the levels agreed to in the trade deal (of 18 per cent), so not too much had changed on the tariff front.

STAR ALLIANCE

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PREMIUM ECONOMY

the premium You Deserve

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Extra legroom

Gourmet meals

Warm Indian hospitality

SCAN TO KNOW MORE

QUICKLY.

Iron ore blending: Adani firm, NMDC, Vale tie up

New Delhi: Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ), through its subsidiary Adani Gangavaram Port Ltd, has signed a memorandum of understanding with NMDC Ltd and Vale SA to develop an integrated iron ore blending facility and dedicated Special Economic Zone (SEZ) at Gangavaram Port. Under the agreement, the three parties will jointly develop, operationalise and manage an SEZ-based ecosystem for blending, value addition and commercialisation of iron ore. The capacity of Gangavaram port is expected to increase to 75 million tonnes. **PTI**

SBI to up green advances portfolio to 10% by 2030

Mumbai: The State Bank of India (SBI) plans to increase its green advances portfolio to 7.5 per cent-10 per cent by 2030, with 25 per cent of these advances to be funded through green lines of credit. Rama Mohan Rao Amara, Managing Director, said, “At SBI, sustainability is integral to our purpose. As we progress towards carbon neutrality by 2030 and Net Zero by 2055, we remain committed to financing India’s green transition and enabling collective climate action.” **OUR BUREAU**

Tighter underwriting leads to lower slippages for PSBs

DISCIPLINED APPROACH. NPA additions for PSBs at 18-24% against 61-93% for PvSBs

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Public sector banks (PSBs) have upped their game on the credit underwriting front, stemming fresh slippages, whereas private sector banks (PvSBs) appear to be lagging.

This is borne out by the central bank data for the last three years and the Department of Financial Services Secretary’s latest statement. During the last three financial years, overall non-performing asset (NPA) additions ranged between 18 per cent and 24 per cent of the NPA opening balance in the case of PSBs.

In sharp contrast, in the case of PvSBs, overall NPA additions ranged from 61 per cent to 93 per cent of the NPA opening balance.

SURPASSING INDUSTRY What this means is that PSBs have been exercising better control on loan sourcing and keeping a close eye on repayments, minimising asset quality deterioration in the process.

All under control			
	FY25 (₹ cr)	FY24 (₹ cr)	FY23 (₹ cr)
PSBs			
Opening balance	3,39,541	4,28,197	5,42,174
Addition	82,762	84,435	98,291
% of opening balance	24.37	19.72	18.13
Reduction	1,38,653	1,73,090	2,12,268
% of opening balance	40.83	40.42	39.15
Closing balance	2,83,650	3,39,541	4,28,197
PvSBs			
Opening balance	1,29,164	1,25,214	1,80,769
Addition	1,18,224	1,16,801	1,10,064
% of opening balance	91.53	93.28	60.89
Reduction	1,18,224	1,12,852	1,65,619
% of opening balance	91.53	90.13	91.62
Closing balance	1,32,674	1,29,164	1,25,214

Source: RBI’s report on trend and progresses of banking in India

Nagaraju M, Secretary, Department of Financial Services (DFS), in a recent speech at the Indian Banks’ Association’s 78th annual general meeting, highlighted that PSBs had been outpacing the banking industry in terms of record low NPA levels, robust profitability and strengthening of the capital base with each passing quarter.

One of the experts assisting the government and IBA with the EASE (Enhanced

Access and Service Excellence) agenda noted that PSBs had overcome asset quality challenges and their focus had shifted from the left hand side of the balance sheet (assets) to the right hand side (liabilities/deposit mobilisation).

NPA REDUCTION Based on RBI data for the last three years, reduction in NPAs for PSBs has been higher than fresh slippages, averaging about 40 per cent

of the opening balance. However, in the case of PvSBs, reduction in NPAs has more or less kept pace with fresh slippages, indicating their willingness to take a hit on the chin via write-offs and move on with the lending business.

UNSECURED LOANS “Slippages in private sector banks are visible in the last three years, going by fresh NPA accretion data,” said Hari Hara Mishra, CEO, Association of ARCs in India. “This could possibly be due to exponential growth in unsecured loans in post-Covid years, amongst others. However, these banks have been able to contain the outstanding gross NPAs through timely action of close monitoring, recovery and upgradation, in addition to sale of these NPAs to asset recovery companies (ARCs),” he added. He emphasised that a healthy balance sheet and control over slippages unlocks growth potential of the banks, which attracts investors and commands a market premium.

‘RBI’s stern cross-selling rules will strengthen banking system’

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI) proposed guidelines on the way banks should advertise, market or sell financial products may have a short-term impact on lenders, but will prove to be positive for the banking sector in the long run, IndusInd Bank CEO Rajiv Anand told *businessline*. “I can fully understand where the RBI is coming from. Their focus over the last few years has been around customer protection. There have been various measures that they undertook over the past three years and this to that extent is a continuation of that process. I am sure they have seen some data which indicates that there has been some element of mis-selling by banks, both private and public sector ones,” Anand said. “So, tightening these to my mind may hurt some banks in the short term, but will make the banking system much stronger in future. It is too early to say if there will be material impact on other income, but the primary focus has to be in terms of adherence through the letter and spirit as far as guidelines are concerned,” he added.



I understand where the RBI is coming from. Their focus over the last few years has been around customer protection

RAJIV ANAND
CEO, IndusInd Bank



According to the draft norms, mis-selling will entail not just refunding amounts taken from the customer, but also shelling out compensation, which could keep the enthusiasm of banks to push third-party products, such as insurance, mutual funds and pension, under check. This could dent their other income, as *businessline* had reported earlier this month. A few private banks are likely to be more impacted due to the proposed norms, analysts said, as the gap between their core income and other income has shrunk sharply over the last few years.

ACQUISITION FINANCE Anand said the RBI’s final guidelines on acquisition financing could provide IndusInd the opportunity to

partner with some of the bigger banks for large transactions. “This has been an ask from Indian banks for a long time. It gives us a fair crack at being able to participate in M&A financing. For banks like us, it gives us the opportunity to partner with some of the larger banks to look at such transactions.” He added that not all transactions will move to Indian banks from foreign banks, but the approval provides a fair playing field to domestic lenders. Private sector banks and many State-owned banks have strong underwriting capability and would be able to compete with foreign lenders. The RBI’s final guidelines say banks can conduct acquisition financing of up to 20 per cent of their tier-1 capital, as against the proposed 10 per cent cap.

Kerala Kumbh, Jayalalithaa, AI Summit on Modi’s latest *Mann Ki Baat* episode

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The AI Impact Summit, revival of the Kerala Kumbh or Mamangam festival after 250 years, and the performance of Indian-origin players across teams at the T20 Cricket World Cup found mentions in Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s *Mann Ki Baat* on Sunday. He also commended farmers and remembered former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa in the latest episode of the monthly broadcast. Highlighting India’s achievements in the field of artificial intelligence (AI), he said the AI Impact Summit showcased how farmers are using technology to keep

track of their livestock and dairy. Two products, the PM said, stood out for leaders from around the world. The Amul booth, he said, showcased how AI is aiding animal care and is helping farmers keep a track of their dairy and livestock 24x7. Secondly, the event displayed how the country is preserving ancient knowledge and manuscripts, and adapting them to suit today’s generation. “This summit proved to be a turning point in how the world will utilise the power of AI,” he said. He added that India launched three ‘Made in India’ AI models at the summit. In an apparent reference to growing annoyance due to banks’ insistence on updating and re-updating KYC,

Modi said, “Please don’t get annoyed. This is for the security of your own money.” KYC is crucial for an individual’s bank account safety amid growing incidents of digital frauds, he added. Modi also commended numerous players of Indian origin at the T20 World Cup. “The Canada team has the highest number of players of Indian origin. Captain Dilpreet Bajwa was born in Gurdaspur, Punjab. Navneet Dhaliwal is from Chandigarh. This list includes many names,” he said. Modi also appreciated farmers and said, “Our farmers are blending tradition and technology, and focusing not just on production but also on quality, value addition and new markets.”

Modi rebukes Cong over ‘shirtless’ protest at AI Summit

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi rebuked the Congress party and Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi over the recent “shirtless” protest by Indian Youth Congress volunteers at the AI Impact Summit in Delhi. Modi alleged that the party had turned an international event hosted by the country into an arena for its “*gandi aur nangi* (dirty and shameless)” politics. Addressing a public gathering after inaugurating Nam Bharat rail and other projects in Meerut (Uttar Pradesh), Modi said that the Congress’ conduct showed how “ideologically bankrupt and impoverished” the party had become.

Modi commended some “opposition” parties for calling out the Congress and hence, “standing with truth and national pride.” He “appreciated the courage” shown by these parties that criticised the incident at the AI summit. YSRCP-led by Jagan Reddy, K Chandrashekar Rao-led BRS and BSP led by Mayawati, none of which is part of the INDI alliance, have criticised the Congress. Modi further alleged that Congress leaders were glorifying those who had insulted the country, instead of feeling ashamed. Limiting the liability to Congress leaders, the PM said the actions did not involve the Trinamool Congress (TMC), the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), or the National



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Conference. “By not allowing Parliament to function, it is their allies who suffer the most,” he added. In what is hinted at as an allusion to Rahul Gandhi, Modi said, “If you want to sit in the Prime Minister’s chair, you must first win the hearts of the people.” He alleged that the crazy (*sar-*

firae) and reckless (*be-lagaam*) leaders of the Congress were bent on destroying the country. **‘A BURDEN ON INDIA’** The PM’s attacks against the Congress leader come after he skipped the customary reply to the President’s address in the Lok Sabha. Modi slammed the Congress over the February 4 incident during the Budget session when women MPs holding banners moved towards his seat in the Lok Sabha, before he was to arrive for his scheduled speech, leading to the adjournment of proceedings for the day. “You cannot become Prime Minister by sending women MPs to occupy seats. What compulsion is there to push mothers and sisters forward like this? Have you

become so hollow?” Modi said and alleged that Congress had become a burden on the country. “But what did the Congress and its ecosystem do? They turned a global event of India into an arena for their *gandi aur nangi* (dirty and shameless) politics. Congress leaders arrived at the venue in front of foreign dignitaries after taking off their clothes. I want to ask Congress leaders — the country already knows you are ‘nange’ (exposed), so why was there any need to stoop further?” After inaugurating development projects worth around ₹12,930 crore in Meerut, he said the double-engine government would continue working towards making Uttar Pradesh the country’s largest economy.

Tata ‘Punch’ es above its weight with 350-km EV

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



Tata Motors on Friday made its strongest push yet for mass-market electric vehicles, unveiling a 40 kWh long-range Punch EV with a claimed 350 km real-world range, sharpening its focus on the sub-₹12 lakh segment where electrification remains limited. The EV version of the popular-selling car starts at ₹9.69 lakh (ex-showroom, Mumbai) and goes up to ₹12.59 lakh. In line with some of its peers, it is also offering the option of battery-as-a-service (BAAS), starting at ₹6.49 lakh with an EMI of ₹2.6/km, reducing the cost of ownership for customers.

India’s passenger vehicle (PV) market sells about 1.3 million cars (65 per cent) annually that are below ₹12 lakh. However, EV penetration in this segment stands at just 1.6 per cent, compared with almost 10 per cent in higher priced bands. Tata’s long-range Punch EV new variant seeks to address entry-buyer concerns around limited range, slow charging, long-term battery durability and resale uncertainty. “If this segment does not get electrified, you will never achieve mainstreaming of EVs in India,” said Shailesh Chandra, MD, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles and Tata Passenger Electric Mobility. “The real battleground is below ₹12 lakh.” Chandra argued that unless this mass segment moves into double-digit penetration, India’s overall EV adoption, currently 4-5 per cent, will continue to expand only gradually. Along with the ex-

tended range, the new Punch EV comes with a lifetime battery warranty with unlimited kilometres. “In higher segments, customers already get 400-plus km range, fast charging and lifetime warranties. We are now bringing those benefits to the entry segment,” Chandra said.

COMPETITION AREAS To address affordability concerns, Tata has introduced a structured financing framework under its BAAS model. Chandra clarified that BAAS separates the battery financing tenures from the vehicle financing tenure, allowing buyers to better compare per-km running costs with petrol vehicles. While Tata remains India’s EV market leader, competition is intensifying. “The presence of top six OEMs in the EV segment show the market has moved from experimental to mainstream. We are not very far away from ICE margins,” he said. Public charging points have increased to around 30,000 from about 500 in 2020, with nearly 70 per cent deployed through open partners rather than solely Tata Power’s network. The company plans to expand its 120 kW ‘Mega Charger’ network to 800 installations by March and to 2,500 next year.

‘Investors view Bitcoin dip as an investment opportunity’

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Bitcoin (BTC) continues with its price slippage, hitting \$65,650 in the third week of February. Yet, individuals with BTC holdings take the trend as an opportunity to invest in cryptocurrency via SIP holdings, says Mridul Gupta, Founding Partner, CoinDCX. The downward trend is even encouraging new investors to enter the market at lower prices, indicating a rise in interest in the virtual asset. *Edited excerpts:*

Why is Bitcoin so volatile currently? This happens every few years. Bitcoin and crypto are global asset classes. A lot of the price movement is due to macro-economic develop-

ments: Risk-on-risk-off sentiment in the US and in global asset classes, geopolitical turmoil and the latest tariff war. There has been a lot of price drop and correction but the long-term view continues to be very strong, backed by regulatory developments around the GENIUS Act, crypto market structures in the US and regulatory adoption in multiple geographies. We have seen the leader adoption has increased at the grassroots level across most countries, including India. In fact, the price correction gives investors a sweet opportunity to enter the space. A lot of these investors are starting their new portfolio deployments into this asset class. So, we will continue to see the price moving up over a longer period of time.

How are investors



People have seen that BTC can touch \$1,20,000 and \$2,50,000. So, any sell-off or downward trend is taken as an opportunity to develop portfolios

MRIDUL GUPTA
Founding Partner, CoinDCX



reacting to the trend? We have not seen any set of pressure. People have continued to maintain their holdings and SIPs into Bitcoin. People are taking every market downturn as an opportunity. They have seen that BTC can touch \$1,20,000 and \$2,50,000. So, any sell-off or downward trend is taken as an opportunity to develop portfolios. We see people investing in

Bitcoin and Ethereum, especially. They continue to build their portfolios and lower their acquisition cost of Bitcoin and Ethereum. Then, there’s a growing need and awareness of SIP in crypto. A lot of people on our platform invest not via direct buy but via SIPs. They will continue to accumulate their Bitcoin custody with SIP offerings. Our SIP users continue to grow.

Karnataka next on mobile phone ban bandwagon for kids under 16? CM cites addiction concerns in House

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah said the State is discussing a possible ban on mobile phones for students under 16, citing concerns over drug use and exposure to harmful content. The CM has sought the views of Vice-Chancellors of universities on restricting students’ mobile phone access. He said several countries, including Australia and in Europe, had taken steps towards the same. On Friday, Karnataka Minister for Electronics, IT/BT Priyank

Kharge told the Assembly that the government is holding consultations on measures for responsible use of artificial intelligence and social media, especially among children, according to *PTI*. Kharge was responding to BJP MLA and former Minister Suresh Kumar during the discussion on the motion of thanks to the Governor’s address. Kumar was referring to Australia’s decision to bar access to social media platforms for those under 16.

CONSULTATIONS ON “Australia has taken a very serious decision that children



under 16 should not be exposed to social media,” Kumar said. He also cited the Economic Survey, which suggested age-based access to online platforms and reducing online teaching to prevent digital addiction.

“Finland has taken action, the UK is considering it, and it has been a couple of months since Australia imposed a ban,” Kharge said, adding that the issue was a serious matter. Kharge added that the State is holding consultations on what needs to be done to ensure responsible use of artificial intelligence and social media. He said his department, along with Meta, is running a digital detox programme for more than three lakh children and one lakh teachers. Reporting by intern Tejaswini S with additional inputs from PTI

They have become a decent share of our overall transacting users. Lastly, a lot of users want to double down on the large-cap tokens like Bitcoin, Ethereum, Solana versus the long tail tokens around meme coins and L2s, blockchain. **In terms of expectations vs reality, how would you assess 2026 Budget?** The key expectation was waiving of the taxation and easing of the capital gains pressure on investors. Today, there’s a lot of action. A lot of founders and start-ups have been out of Dubai. There’s a lot happening in offshore exchanges. So, Indian capital continues to go out. That acceptance is now getting into the right policy circles and think tanks. So, we have moved a step forward on the acceptance that the capital of Indian investors will move abroad if

the taxation laws continue to be this strong and not on par with other investment asset classes. But how to put a structure around it and how to amend the plan of execution is not yet on paper. **What are CoinDCX’s plans for 2026?** We will continue to invest a lot more in education. A lot of people have been trying to understand more about the asset class.

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QUICKLY.

RBI builds secure data centre in Odisha

New Delhi: The RBI has built a high-security data centre in Odisha, strategically located well away from potential cross-border threat zones and high seismic-risk regions, as part of efforts to safeguard critical financial infrastructure and strengthen the continuity of core systems. The facility is designed to house core computing systems supporting the central bank's currency management, payment and settlement operations. **PII**

Power surge to lift coal demand: mjunction

New Delhi: The country's coal demand, which remained weak earlier in the current financial year, is poised for a boost in the coming days on the back of a sharp turnaround in electricity consumption, an industry expert said on Sunday. Vinaya Varma, MD of mjunction services Ltd, a B2B e-commerce platform and a joint venture of SAIL and Tata Steel, said after successive months of negative growth in October and November, power demand staged a strong recovery in December with 6.3 per cent growth. **PII**

Yes Bank looks to exit FY26 with RoA of 1%



New Delhi: Yes Bank expects to close the ongoing financial year with a return on assets of 1 per cent, said the bank's CFO Niranjan Banodkar. "The bank will exit the current fiscal year with an RoA of 1 per cent and on an annual basis, the RoA will exceed 1 per cent in the next fiscal year," he said. **PII**

DRDO to move towards unified battlefield, cyber data application

HIGH ALERT. D-G Chandrika Kaushik on the preparedness and challenges in leapfrogging into next-gen warfare

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) is at the forefront of contextualising, exploring and innovating to come up with capacity- and capability-enhancement applications for the armed forces through artificial intelligence, machine learning and data analytics. In the backdrop of the AI Impact Summit India 2026, which concluded on Saturday, Chandrika Kaushik, Director General (Production Co-ordination & Services Interaction), DRDO, talks about its preparedness and the challenges involved in leapfrogging into next-generation warfare.

Edited excerpts:

How can DRDO define priority AI mission areas aligned with India's national security doctrine?
The National Security Strategy (NSS) tenets include credible deterrence, border security, maritime domain awareness and multi-domain superiority. We know that in June 2018, the government published the National Strategy for AI, focusing on how the nation can leverage transformative AI technologies to ensure inclusive growth in all sectors of society. And subsequently, in February 2021, the government published the Principles for Responsible AI. In consonance with these policy initiatives, the DRDO has formulated guidelines and a framework for evaluating the trustworthiness of AI as well as an independent verification and validation framework for AI-based sys-

tems released in 2025 and 2026. DRDO has been actively working in niche application areas of AI for ISR applications, man-machine teaming, natural language processing and unmanned autonomous systems. Against asymmetric threats from adversaries like, for example, massed swarms and hybrid tactics, embedding of user-aligned and trustworthy AI, human oversight and edge compute efficiency are being incorporated at the design stage itself.

In addition to this, DRDO will keep exploring new application areas of AI according to use cases. DRDO will also focus on promulgation and implementation of trustworthiness and verification & validation frameworks in conjunction with all the stakeholders, including the armed forces, QA agencies, academia, industry and the Department of Telecom.

What is the update on the multiple labs and centres such as the Centre for Artificial Intelligence & Robotics the DRDO has dedicated to AI?
CAIR has been working extensively on fundamental and applied research in AI for defence-specific problems. This includes machine perception, AI-based decision support, reasoning systems and knowledge extraction, which can be applied to unmanned systems, autonomous platforms and real-time information analysis for battlefield scenarios. In addition to this, according to the directions of the Prime Minister, DRDO created a dedicated Young Scientist Laboratory in the area of AI to carry out research in niche-technological do-

For defence AI, data localisation and insulation from foreign cloud exposure are strategic imperatives, not just IT preferences

CHANDRIKA KAUSHIK
Director General (Production Co-ordination & Services Interaction), DRDO



mains. The DYSL AI centre at Bengaluru has been working on AI-based advanced technologies and language translation for situational awareness.

Better coordination within the armed forces is also required for real-time operational feedback. How can that happen?

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) constituted the Defence AI Council (DAIC) in February 2019 as the apex decision-making body for AI adoption in the defence sector. It was established as part of India's structured push towards AI-enabled military capabilities.

DAIC provides strategic direction and policy-level oversight for AI in the armed forces. At the working level, the Defence AI Project Agency (DAIPA) works as an executive arm that implements AI projects approved by DAIC. It operates under the MoD/DRDO framework. DAIPA translates AI strategy into operational projects and deployable systems.

What lessons can India draw from AI defence ecosystems in the US and China?

The US operates with the model of institutional integration and China works with the model of state-driven military-civil fusion. The US created the Chief Digital & Artificial Intelligence Office, merging AI, data, analytics and digital transformation into one unified authority. In the Indian context, DAIC (strategy) and DAIPA (projects) can integrate data governance, cloud, AI and cyber under one operational umbrella and ensure cross-service interoperability early.

However, in case of China's state-driven military-civil fusion strategy, civilian AI breakthroughs rapidly migrate into defence systems.

On similar lines, India may strengthen structured collaboration between DRDO, IITs, IISc and private AI firms, incentivise dual-use AI research to create classified research corridors in academia.

In addition to this, India's AI strategy will be executed in consonance with the PM's vision of Manav for AI. Manav serves as an acronym representing five principles — moral and ethical system, accountable governance, national sovereignty, accessible and inclusive techno-

logy and valid/legitimate systems.

There is also a need to standardise battlefield, ISR, UAV, naval and cyber data. Is there a move towards that?

There is growing recognition on the need to standardise and integrate data across battlefields, intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR), UAV, naval and cyber domains, and early steps are underway. Modern military AI and decision-support systems rely on consistent, interoperable data formats and pipelines, especially when fusing data. DRDO's ETAI Framework (October 2024) mandates pipeline standards for data annotation, versioning and secure handling across AI/ML artifacts.

Data localisation and protection from foreign cloud exposure is equally important. Your thoughts on this.

For defence AI, data localisation and insulation from foreign cloud exposure are strategic imperatives, not just IT preferences. In addition to privacy concerns, data localisation and protection is essential to ensure sovereignty,

operational continuity and wartime resilience. Mandating sovereign infrastructure clusters for classified data with air-gapped networks has to be the norm. This is in line with our NSS. The government is planning a comprehensive five-layer AI Stack Strategy to develop capabilities across application, model, compute, infrastructure and energy. This will duly address the challenges of data localisation and protection from foreign cloud exposure.

Fall in imports from Russia set to raise India's crude oil costs by \$2-3/barrel: Kpler

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As India begins reducing Russian crude oil imports under pressure from the US, its overall crude oil import bill is expected to increase \$2-3 per barrel, which can be offset by Venezuelan barrels, albeit partially.

Global real time data and analytics provider Kpler said India is not positioned to fully replace Russian barrels without cost from a market structure perspective.

"Russian grades have provided a rare combination of medium sour quality, stable availability and discounted pricing, which have been particularly valuable for complex refiners optimised for sour processing," it pointed out.

OVERALL COSTS
Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling, told *businessline*: "As India reduces Russian barrels, the overall crude cost is expected to go up \$2-3 per barrel. However, cheaper Venezuelan crude buy could partially offset this. Again, Venezuelan crude import will only be at a marginal or supplementary level and cannot replace Russian barrels."

That said, Venezuelan supply is structurally constrained by production limits, logistics and compliance risks. It is unlikely to fully replace Russian volumes, but it can help reduce the cost impact at the margin end if flows continue to build, he added.

RUSSIAN CRUDE
Kpler expects Russian crude imports to India at around 1.2 million barrels per day (mb/d) in February 2026, easing towards roughly 800-1,000 thousand b/d (kb/d) next month. "However, we

continue to see this as a short-term stabilisation, rather than a return to the mid-2025 peak, and we expect Russia's share in India's crude slate to gradually stabilise to a lower range in 2026 compared to 2024/2025, as commercial and policy frictions build," Ritolia anticipates.

Last week, ratings agency CareEdge said that "going forward, a compelled shift away from Russian crude towards a blend of Venezuelan, US and Middle Eastern grades is likely to increase the weighted average cost of India's crude oil sourcing by \$1.5-2 per barrel, directly compressing the GRM premium that Indian refiners have enjoyed in recent years".

Hardik Shah, Director, CareEdge Ratings, said Indian downstream oil sector's performance is currently driven by the dual engines of high gross refinery margins and healthy marketing margins.

"As we transition into FY27, the narrative is likely to shift from high GRMs to moderate but sustainable GRMs. While GRMs are expected to moderate from their recent peak levels due to global supply pressures and realignments in crude oil sourcing, they are likely to settle at \$6-8 per barrel, which is accretive to the historical average," he explained.

On favouring Urals over the US or Venezuelan crude, a refinery official explained that refinery margins factor in multiple variables, such as crude differentials, processing yields, product pricing and operational efficiency metrics. Urals, Arab Medium or for that matter Merer (Venezuela), have different API gravity and sulphur content. Each has a different impact on processing costs, product yields and margin realisation.

Indian Hotels Company sees double-digit revenue growth in Q4 on rising room rates

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

The Indian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL) sees continued double-digit revenue growth in the fourth quarter of this fiscal, driven by an increase in average room rates.

In the third quarter, IHCL reported 12 per cent year-on-year revenue growth.

RevPAR (revenue per available room) rose 9 per cent.

The company expects the growth trend to continue in the March-end quarter with several high-profile events, such as India AI Impact summit, the T-20 World Cup and weddings.

In the post Q3 investor conference call, IHCL MD and CEO Puneet Chhatwal said it would be fair to assume approximately double-digit RevPAR growth in the fourth quarter.

"If not, then it could be 9, it could be 8.8, but I think with a bit of tailwind that we

India's travel and tourism ecosystem continues to deepen, driven by rising disposable incomes, infrastructure investments, weddings, spiritual tourism and premiumisation of experiences

PUNEET CHHATWAL
Managing Director and CEO, IHCL



are currently having, we could get anything between 9 per cent and 10 per cent RevPAR growth, but definitely you should expect a total revenue growth in a similar range as you have experienced in the past," said Chhatwal.

DOMESTIC TRAVEL
While foreign tourist arrivals are yet to cross the pre-2019 figure, domestic travel re-

mains robust. A favourable demand supply dynamic continues to drive RevPAR growth.

LUXURY SEGMENT
The luxury segment, too, is performing well, contributing nearly 70 per cent of IHCL's operating revenue.

"We believe this is not cyclical alone, but a structural change that is here to stay. Because India's travel and

tourism ecosystem continues to deepen, driven by rising disposable incomes, infrastructure investments, meetings, incentive, conference and exhibitions (MICE) demand, weddings, spiritual tourism and premiumisation of experiences. On the supply side, additions remain measured in several key micro markets and this is ultimately supporting the RevPAR growth," said Chhatwal. "For IHCL, this translates into continued pricing power across segments, improved mix and yield management, operating leverage flowing through to margins. As a result, we expect steady like-for-like revenue growth to remain a meaningful contributor to earnings expansion," he added.

At present, the company earns 53 per cent of its revenue from key domestic business cities.

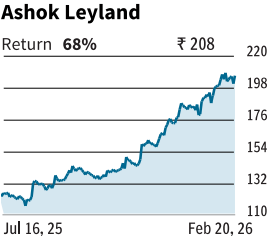
Domestic leisure destinations and international markets contribute 15 per cent and 22 per cent respectively.

TODAY'S PICK.

Ashok Leyland (₹208.80): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

The stock of Ashok Leyland has been in a steady uptrend since April last year. It established a rally on the back of the support at ₹100. On February 11, it hit a record high of ₹215.35. Following this, it witnessed some moderation. On Friday, the scrip rebounded from the support at ₹202, where the 21-day moving average and a trendline support coincide.



This indicates that the bulls have regained traction after a pause and thus, we expect the stock to rally and make fresh highs in the forthcoming sessions. Buy the stock at ₹208 and place a stop-loss at ₹200. When the price rises to ₹215, revise the stop-loss to ₹206. Tighten the stop-loss to ₹210 when the stock reaches ₹225. Book profits at ₹230.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

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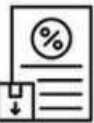
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Tricky pitch

Despite US SC ruling, India cannot give up trade talks

The US Supreme Court’s majority ruling against reciprocal tariffs has opened up a scenario of bewildering possibilities for India and the rest of the world. The court has struck down the exercise of powers under the International Economic Emergency Powers Act, 1977, as a case of executive overreach, holding that Congress should not have been bypassed. The world watches with bated breath on what the Trump administration might unleash next.



The US has already invoked Section 122 of the Trade Act, 1974 to impose global tariffs of 15 per cent to deal with a ‘large and serious’ trade deficit. This can run only for 150 days. A review, possibly with legislative sanction, might be needed for an extension. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has darkly hinted that Section 338 of the Tariff Act, 1930 might come into play. The section allows for tariffs up to 50 per cent on ‘discriminatory’ foreign imports, but it is vague in scope, and about implementing agencies. Meanwhile, the tools being used are Section 301 of the Trade Act, 1974, and Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act, 1962. These two have to be preceded by time-consuming investigations establishing unfair trade practices and national security concerns, respectively.

So, it would be premature to assume that high tariffs are a thing of the past. What is more likely is that future options exercised by the Trump administration could be litigated. The Congress may not endorse these options readily, as it showed in Canada’s case. While the scenario is volatile, India and others seem to be better placed after the ruling to deal with a befuddled Trump administration. They are now faced with 15 per cent plus MFN tariffs on their exports. Country-specific reciprocal tariffs, 18 per cent in India’s case as per the framework agreement, have ceased to be, but sectoral tariffs on steel and aluminium globally — under Section 232 — remain. It is estimated that over half of India’s exports to the US will now attract 15 per cent plus MFN tariffs.

The big question now is: how should India deal with an incensed President Trump in its ongoing trade talks? Rescinding the admittedly one-sided interim framework deal is not an option, for three reasons: first, in principle, there are gains to be had from a well-tailored pact with the US; second, it is possible to leverage the confusion arising out of the court order to arrive at favourable terms; and third, a walkout can provoke a needlessly hostile response. A clause in the February 6 joint statement, in fact, says: “In the event of any changes to the agreed upon tariffs of either country, the United States and India agree that the other country may modify its commitments.” India can clear its positions on areas such as application of standards, particularly in agriculture, exercise of digital sovereignty, and the need to delink trade from geopolitical alignments — issues mentioned in the joint statement. In other words, a deal is on; the terms should change.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Trump’s Board of Peace: serving private interests more
In Gaza, aid still trickles in at levels relief agencies say are far below what is required. Temporary shelters are scarce. Reconstruction materials are restricted by Israel’s controls on goods entering the territory. Conditions, say the UN, remain “dire”. . The announcement that the US would transfer \$10 billion to President Trump’s newly convened Board of Peace is hard to reconcile with the reality on the ground. Even worse is that Washington has paid only a fraction of its UN arrears — \$160 million against more than \$4 billion owed. This raises the obvious question: why is a private initiative being capitalised so heavily while existing UN mechanisms remain cash-strapped? Funnelling state funds into a body chaired by Mr Trump suggests foreign policy is serving private interests, not the public good. (LONDON, FEBRUARY 20)

讀賣新聞

THE YOMIURI SHIMBUN

Judiciary won’t tolerate Trump’s high-handed approach
The US Supreme Court ruled on Friday that “The International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) does not authorise the president to impose tariffs,” in connection with so-called reciprocal tariffs imposed by the US government on countries and regions worldwide. The court determined in its ruling that under the US Constitution the authority to impose tariffs lies with Congress, and that imposing tariffs without congressional approval exceeded the presidential authority granted by this law. Since its founding, the United States has rigorously maintained the separation of powers among the judiciary, legislature and executive branches, preventing a descent into autocracy through mutual checks and balances. (TOKYO, FEBRUARY 22)



SHYAM VENKATESH

In a major 6-3 decision on February 20, 2026, the US Supreme Court ruled that the tariffs imposed under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act. (IEEPA) were not legal. In response, the President Trump has imposed a global tariff of 15 per cent under Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974 citing “large and serious” balance-of-payments deficits. More sector specific and permanent tariffs under Section 301 “against unfair trade practices” can be imposed but procedural formalities could take months. Even this 15 per cent tariff under Section 122 may be challenged in court. They have to prove “a balance of payment crisis” exists

The SC ruling could be a turning point in the political fortunes of both parties as they compete for control of the House and the Senate in November. Early polling this year had shown that nearly 75 per cent of Americans held the tariffs responsible for increase in the cost of living and drop in hiring. Republicans will find it hard to defend a policy they supported that was not legal. Democrats who were already pointing to executive overreach will project the court’s ruling as vindication. They would run on “returning” the \$175 billion or \$200 billion revenue from tariffs collected illegally to the small businesses and farmers, traditionally the GOP base.

The 15 per cent tariff would expire in July 2026 forcing a Congressional vote just at the run up to the elections. Vulnerable Republicans in manufacturing states will have to decide between supporting the President’s agenda and addressing the “cost-of-living” concerns of their constituents.

The November midterm election is attracting global attention. The driver is the disruption caused by the current Administration in geo-politics and world order. Change has been frenetic and volatile. It has challenged the world. The midterms are likely to alter the balance of power in Congress and consequently US foreign and trade policy.

In the two party system, the GOP now controls all three branches of government — executive, judicial and legislative. The executive branch has been testing the limits of its authority with no pushback from either of the other two branches of government. Witness the punitive tariffs, coercive diplomacy and even threats of annexation.

The SC decision striking down some tariffs may be a temporary respite until they are legitimised. The legislature seems to have abdicated its authority in areas where it has the sole purview. So many executive orders are being



STRIKING. The US Supreme Court ruling could be a turning point in the political fortunes of both parties. Most American now blame the tariffs for increase in the cost of living

challenged in the Supreme Court that one of the justices has complained of being overworked!

The midterm elections were conceived by the US constitution as an instrument of checks and balances. The objective was to ensure stability in federal governance and at the same time to remain responsive to changing public opinion by establishing different term lengths for members of Congress. The entire House of Representatives is up for election every even numbered year. Although members of the Senate serve for six years, one-third of the senate is up for election every two years. By keeping two-thirds of the Senate stable for six years it was intended that their experience and policy familiarity would lend stability should a new President be elected.

Since the President serves a four-year term, an election cycle occurs at the middle of a President’s term. The US Congress has totally 535 voting members, with 435 in the House and 100 in the Senate. The number of House seats allotted for each state depends on its population as per the recent census. In the Senate each state has 2 seats.

Although the midterms are statewide and local to the districts, they have become a referendum on the incumbent President’s performance. Since the end of World War II, the president’s party

Recent results have shown that voters are more likely to vote based on their opinion of the president rather than the local candidate

has lost an average of 26 seats in the House and four seats in the Senate per midterm cycle.

Recent results have shown that voters are more likely to vote based on their opinion of the president rather than the local candidate. Since 2000, there have been six midterm election cycles. The historical pattern of the president’s party losing seats in Congress has largely held, with 2002 being the only outlier, where the President’s party gained seats in both chambers due to the 9/11 attacks.

HOUSE AND SENATE FORECAST

House seat losses strongly correlate to the President’s approval rating. Presidents with approval ratings below 50 per cent typically see much steeper losses. The President’s favourability is currently at 35 per cent. On key issues like immigration, economy, tariffs, and foreign policy, his disapproval is at more than 50 per cent. Therefore it looks more likely that the Democrats would control the House come November.

The most likely outcome in the Senate is a narrow Republican majority (51 or 52 seats), but a Democratic majority is no longer being ruled out by major forecasters. For Democrats to gain control, they need 51 seats since the VP has the tie-breaking vote, as the President of the Senate. In the Senate, Republicans have the advantage because most of the 22 GOP seats up for election are in states Donald Trump won by 10+ points in 2024. This gives Republicans a high “floor”. The Democratic momentum stems from the 2026 polling that indicates Independent voters trending toward Democrats. A “Blue Wave” could see Democrats potentially

sweep the “Toss-Up” seats and control of the Senate.

Aspirants for office are tapping into the sentiments of people who feel left behind. It is no longer the right vs the left but the top vs the bottom.

Americans across party lines agree that the wealth gap between the top 1 per cent and the rest is a major issue. They believe the President’s policies favour the wealthy and recent tariffs have made items like food and housing less affordable. The top 1 per cent own 50 per cent of the stock market. The bottom half of population owns just 1.1 per cent

Roughly 81 per cent of all Americans, including 66 per cent of Republicans, believe that the rich in the US have too much power and influence. And this was before they saw the Epstein files!

There are other imponderables besides the impact of the Supreme Court striking down the 2025 tariffs, that could upend the election forecast.

Both the GOP and Democrats are attempting to ‘redistrict’ state maps to favour their party. The President wants to nationalise elections although the Constitution empowers the states to conduct elections. Attempts are afoot to seize voter rolls in an attempt to “purge” them. Banning of mail-in ballots on suspicion of fraud is being touted although none has been proven. The talk of armed guards at polling booths would diminish voter turnout in view of the recent Minneapolis fiasco.

November will determine whether 2027 brings a predictable path forward or a steeper drop on the 2026 roller coaster.

The writer is an Indian-origin resident in US

Why the rush to set up data centres in India

Less than 6 per cent of the world’s data storage is located here, despite the country producing about a fifth of world data

Atanu Biswas

US President Donald Trump’s trade adviser, Peter Navarro, recently stated on the podcast Real America Voice with Steve Bannon that US-based platforms like ChatGPT use electricity in the US while servicing consumers in India (and China). Navarro wondered why Americans are footing the bill for AI services in India. His comments coincide with tensions between India and the US due to tariffs, US claims to be mediating tensions between India and Pakistan, and stricter immigration laws, such as mass deportations and restrictions on H-1B visas.

The 2014 film, *Transcendence*, starring Johnny Depp, highlights advancements in data centres, AI, the Internet of Things, and nanotechnologies. One might get more than a few ideas about the future of data centres from *Transcendence* — it serves as an excellent example of green technologies, cooling, power, etc.

Navarro hinted at a possible policy change by the Trump administration in the podcast, pointing to growing electricity costs that are directly related to the quick growth of AI data centres. In reality, the average US electricity bill increased by 5 per cent in October compared to the same period last year, according to data from America’s Energy

Information Administration, increasing political sensitivity about energy expenses. Additionally, the economic and environmental effects of massive data centres that use a lot of water and electricity have drawn more attention to AI companies.

Applications across a variety of industries, including finance, healthcare, education, transportation, defence, and e-commerce, are now powered by AI.

Modern data centres are essential to this expanding use of AI. Less than 6 per cent of the world’s data storage infrastructure is located in India, despite the country producing almost a fifth of the world’s data. As data demand increases in the most populous country in the world, some of the largest business houses in India are rushing in to invest in data centres.

CAPACITY EXPANSION

According to a Macquarie Research report dated October 27, India now has 1.4 GW of operating data centre capacity, 1.4 GW under development, and another about 5 GW in the planning stage.

In fact, American tech giants like Microsoft, Amazon, Google, and Meta are investing \$67.5 billion in India’s AI and data centre infrastructure as the gold rush for setting up data centres continues, wagering on the country’s expanding role as a global digital hub.



BIG PLANS. Launch of a wide range of data centres into space GETTY IMAGES

India’s scale and the business opportunity are undoubtedly at the core of this movement.

The disparity between India’s data and data centres offers the American Big Techs both an opportunity and a challenge. Costs are reduced, speed is increased, and control over data flows is strengthened when data centres are built closer to users.

Furthermore, long-term infrastructure investments by multinational technology companies have gained impetus due to data localisation and governmental pushes.

Additionally, data centres are crucial to the US economy. The US GDP grew by just 0.1 per cent in the first half of 2025 without data centres. Indeed, nearly all of the growth is being driven by data centres and technological investment,

according to Harvard economist Jason Furman. The growth of the US GDP would be almost stagnant without this technological surge. Major tech companies are making significant investments in data centres.

By storing and analysing data, text, graphics, code, and other information sources, data centres support the expanding usage of AI. However, how will the data centres themselves fare in the future? They undoubtedly have issues with the supply of water and electricity.

AMBITIOUS PLANS

In fact, tech billionaires now want to relocate AI’s enormous energy demands outside the planet. There are huge engineering challenges, though. However, SpaceX’s ambitious plans for a more than \$30 billion IPO in 2026 concentrate on raising capital for Elon Musk’s most recent ambitious project: launching a wide range of data centres into space.

In recent months, rival space billionaire Jeff Bezos has also spoken a lot about developing this technology, which may sound like a proposal from science fiction.

Therefore, such technical advancement may also render Navarro’s concern obsolete in the future.

The writer is Professor of Statistics, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata

● BELOW THE LINE



Media adds to chaos

While enough has been said about organisational and logistical issues at

the government’s AI Impact Summit, the media (and the public at large) too played a part in making the situation tough to handle. Prominent personalities would get off the stage after their talk, only to be mobbed by television journalists looking for the coveted “exclusive”.

And even as the security personnel (a paltry proportion of mediapersons) tried to shield them, attendees would rush in with their smartphones, trying to click selfies. Some guests

were truly traumatised.

Cracking the walnut

The Customs authorities recently detained a container vessel carrying some 46 consignments of Chinese walnuts that were being passed off as Afghan ones. This has been happening for years and the black sheep in the Customs have been getting away. In one instance about a decade ago, a Customs official was raided based on a tip-off. But the official not only managed to get off

the hook, but was even promoted. Indications of the rot in the system.

The Punch story

A baby macaque named Punch at Ichikawa Zoo has won hearts worldwide. Brands and institutions are also riding on the viral moment to make a point. In a post, Delhi Police wrote, “Punch’s story reminds us — everyone needs someone and we’re always here for you. Dial 112.” Kerala Tourism also joined in, sharing an image of the baby monkey with the

caption, “A little lost. A lot loved. That’s the magic of Kerala.” Punch was abandoned by his mother shortly after birth, prompting caretakers to give him an orangutan plush toy for comfort. Videos of him clinging to the toy struck an emotional chord with viewers across the globe. Ikea was the first to react. It donated stuffed toys to Punch and the zoo and has since seen a spike in demand for its orangutan plush toy globally. **Our Bureaus**

ON THE CAMPAIGN
TRAIL.

The season of love continued to inspire brands during a fortnight that also saw some great storytelling by both legacy and D2C brands

Well paired!

Humour has always been the leitmotif of Pidilite's brands and that shines through in Shoeife's Valentine's Day campaign 'Jodi Salamat Rahe'. The film takes a playful, '90s Bollywood-inspired route, complete with classic melodrama and a song-and-dance routine. Adding to the fun, Blinkit makes an unexpected cameo, amplifying the quirky storyline. We see a couple running towards each other in filmi style, until the hero's sprint is stalled because his shoe heel came off — but Shoeife, via Blinkit, takes care. Punning at multiple levels, the romantic pair and the shoe pair are allowed to bond in this Ogilvy-made creative.

Futuristic love

What happens when a robot falls in love with a mobike? FCB Interface's new film for Hero MotoCorp shows a robot drawn to Glamour X's beautiful design and advanced features. Set to the dreamy song 'Pehla Nasha', the film, which sees the infatuated robot chasing the motorcycle, has several sweet moments and perfectly enumerates all the best features of the 125cc bike.

Gripping tale

The commercial that scores a perfect hit during the cricket T-20 series is the one from CEAT, featuring an uncooperative tyre. The ad shows filmmaker Zoya Akhtar trying to direct an action scene where the car has to screech and skid. Instead, shot after shot is taken and the car refuses to go off control. Where's the skid, she asks. The answer stares back at her as she glances at the tyre. The storyline sells the tyre's ability to grip, and it does so grippingly.

Out of the mouth of kids

Clean label brand The Whole Truth, which has entered the kid's category with a new range of snacking bars and milk mixes, takes a jab at the claims of big brands in a hard-hitting new ad. Even as parents extol the virtues of various products made by big brands, their smart kids quickly point to the labels and start questioning them.

Clearing the confusion

Bajaj Broking's new ad campaign, airing during the T20 World Cup, is based on the idea that investment need not be complicated. Rooted in its brand theme 'Seedhi Simple Investing — Bajaj Broking', it features multiple short films showing daily situations where one faces confusion (for example, ambiguous washroom symbols or lift buttons) and contrasts them with how simplified investing has become.

NUGGET.

Q-comm fires up ad industry

Two reports on India's advertising industry highlight quick commerce's rise as an important media choice. WPP Media's This Year Next Year (TYNY) advertising forecast projects that advertising revenue will reach ₹2,01,891 crore in 2026, at a growth rate of 9.7 per cent. There will be an incremental addition of ₹17,844 crore over 2025, says the report, which underscores India's position as a top 10 global advertising market, with the sector representing 0.5 per cent of India's GDP. Channel-wise, commerce-led advertising emerges as the fastest-growing segment, at 24.2 per cent, driven by the convergence of retail media, quick commerce and social commerce, says the report. Other digital channels comprising non-search, non-commerce will grow at 11.1 per cent, while location-based media such as OOH and cinema will expand at 8.9 per cent. Meanwhile, Madison World's Pitch Madison Advertising Report (PMAR) 2026, says India's advertising market grew 12 per cent year-on-year to reach ₹1,55,105 crore in 2025, under an expanded ADEX definition that incorporates quick commerce and MSME digital spends. The report says digital accounts for 60 per cent of India's ad market, with traditional media at 40 per cent. It found that q-comm advertising on platforms like Blinkit, Zepto and Swiggy Instamart scaled up from ₹1,325 crore to ₹4,000 crore, a 202 per cent jump. PMAR 2026 projects q-comm ADEX at ₹6,000 crore in 2026, implying 50 per cent growth to cement its status as a core performance engine.

● AD-LIBBING

‘Profit-ad spend link appears broken’

NEAR VISION. Geographical and technological volatility is driving a shorter-term focus on spending, says Sir Martin Sorrell

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

Advertising veteran Sir Martin Sorrell, who founded and built WPP into one of the world's largest ad and marketing services companies before going on to launch the digital-only data-driven company S4 Capital, was in Delhi recently. One of ad industry's most influential voices, 81-year-old Sorrell says AI will raise the quality of work, even as he worries that there could be a real problem when machines become more powerful than people. Excerpts from a conversation on how the agency business is changing.

How real is the AI disruption for the advertising and media planning sectors?

It is significant. I mean, the stock market is clearly signalling that holding companies are in trouble as a result of AI. We'll see whether that turns out to be true. But from the perspective of visualisation and copywriting, it is significantly compressing the time taken to make an ad and the cost of an ad, which means agencies will have to shift from a revenue model and the hours model to an output model with personalisation at scale, what I call "Netflix on steroids". It is a huge opportunity from the perspective of media planning and buying. Meta has Advantage+, Google has Performance Max (PMax — AI-driven automated advertising offerings). Uniting Advantage+ and PMax with Sora and Veo 3, you get an end-to-end production model, including creative, production, media planning and buying. So the agency has to get closer to the platforms and clients. They will need to realise that the majority of things are going to be decided by algorithmic analysis and not manual. So, in that



PEOPLE VS AI POWER. Sir Martin Sorrell, ad veteran and founder of digital-only data-driven company S4 Capital

space, there will not be a need for as many people as before. We currently have three models followed by companies — outsourced, embedded and in-house. The advice we give clients is that agility is key. You should take back control. You should do more internally — for example, media planning, not everywhere, but in many cases, because there's nobody who knows more about your business than you. The other aspect is first-party data. Consolidating data at scale is critically important. And, finally, what I call democratisation and flattening of organisations and getting people to work together more efficiently.

What is your advice for a

young person entering the advertising and media buying industry? Learn Chinese, Spanish and code, and then focus on the digital and data part of the business, because that is where the opportunity is, with the traditional part of the business going down. If I was coming out of university, I think I would go to America or the Middle East or Asia. You have said that the traditional co-relations seen as markers of economic health have broken down. What are the new markers? I think the traditional correlation between corporate profitability and ad spend seems to have broken down. Firstly, the \$300 billion tra-

ditional media ad spend is going south, while digital spend at \$900 billion is going north. Companies like Google and Meta are investing astronomical figures. They spend more on capex than opex. So that's where the difference is. Ad spend strategies have also become more short-term. Listed companies need to report revenues on a quarterly basis, and I do agree with Trump that we should get rid of quarterly reporting. Private equity firms, their whole period is five years, and they control a big part of the economy. And then venture capital, they're asking, "Where's my exit?" So, by their nature, people are focusing more on the short term. And the question arises: Why am I spending all this money on this up-

per-funnel stuff? You know, Olympics and World Cup, when I have to appear in front of investors to justify spending? It's also the geographical volatility, the fragmentation and the technological volatility that drives people to a shorter-term focus on spending. So at mid-funnel and lower-funnel, activation and performance becomes even more important.

What is the future strategy of S4 Capital, especially in India?

We're digital-only, data-driven. We go to market faster, better, cheaper and so the model is right. Nearly 50 per cent of our revenues comes from tech, so we're under the gun because they're spending so much on capex. So we have to get our act together on growth and margins. But we have improved quite significantly and our balance sheet is getting in better shape. We have a good set of clients. We have done a lot of M&A and we need to integrate those even better because we've only done surface work. We have a small business here in India, with about 250 people, and we are looking at scaling it up. How will AI impact creativity? I was speaking to somebody who's regarded as a creative genius and his point was there's so much work out there that's not good and is crappy. In his view, AI will raise the level. The genius stuff still will be done, but he thinks the general level of work will be raised. It's a tool that people can use to improve the general level of work. The real problem is what happens when machines become more powerful than people? I mean, it is a worry. I mean, we've gone past the Oppenheimer moment, which is when we can control this stuff. I mean, now these platforms and companies are nation states.

Behind the scenes, the quiet threshold moments at the AI Impact Summit

In sectors ranging from agriculture to education and sustainability to multilingual access, meet the AI builders

DIGITAL
GADFLY
SHUBHO SENGUPTA

If global tech summits were theatre, then the AI Impact Summit would qualify as a full-scale opening night — bright lights, big promises, a distinguished audience, and...er, just the faintest hint that something backstage may have required a touch of improvisation. While the spotlights tracked ministers, bureaucrats, investors, and marquee names, something quieter and far more stirring was unfolding in the wings. Founders from towns better known for railway junctions than research labs, engineers who had coded more often under tube lights than studio lights, and small teams with improbable ideas suddenly found themselves presenting to the world. For them, this was not merely a summit — it was a threshold moment. Here's a list of the interesting AI start-ups I came across; I have also thrown in a few that my friends and circles on X found interesting.

● Agriculture
Agrograde
AI-powered optical sorting and grading machines for fruits and vegetables (such as potatoes and onions) that analyse size, colour, shape and defects in real time to reduce post-harvest losses and improve marketability. Global potential: Scalable to smallholder farmers in developing countries facing high produce wastage; proven in 12-plus Indian States with partnerships such as Bosch and Nvidia; suitable for export-oriented agricultural markets in Africa and Southeast Asia.

Hanunnotech
AI- and IoT-driven analytics for dairy, agriculture and animal husbandry, including wearable sensors such as the 'Cow Neck-lace' for monitoring vital signs, predicting yield and managing heat stress. Global potential: Supports food security in dairy-dependent regions like South Asia and Africa; low-power machine learning enables affordable deployment for small farmers globally.

Aalgorix
Precision agriculture AI for yield optimisation, crop monitoring



LOCAL LANGUAGE MODEL. The Sarvam AI booth at the recently held AI Impact Summit in New Delhi BLOOMBERG

and resource management. Global potential: Improves productivity for small farmers in climate-vulnerable regions such as South Asia and sub-Saharan Africa. ● Health
BigOHealth
AI-powered health monitoring wearables and platforms for real-time patient data analysis and preventive care. Global potential: Affordable remote monitoring suited to bridging rural and urban healthcare gaps in developing countries; integrates with telemedicine ecosystems.

A I V E d a
AI platform integrating Vedic wellness principles with modern health insights to provide personalised recommendations and holistic care. Global potential: Appeals to expanding wellness markets across Asia and diaspora populations; blends traditional knowledge with scalable technology. Eka Care
Digital health platform with AI tools such as EkaScribe for automating prescriptions, patient histories and records, enabling rural doctors to serve more patients efficiently. Global potential: Keyboard-free AI scribes can transform primary care in resource-limited health systems, similar to those in India, Africa and Southeast Asia.

Carenow Healthcare
AI-driven patient triage, care co-ordination and monitoring systems that streamline hospital and clinic workflows. Global potential: Reduces over-

load in public health systems; scalable for emerging markets with high patient volumes and limited staff. Ottobots
Autonomous robots for hospital logistics to deliver medicines and navigate complex environments independently. Global potential: Reduces staff workload in overstretched healthcare facilities; adaptable to hospitals in emerging economies. ● Education
A I Planet
Community-driven AI platforms and tools for education, skill development and collaborative AI building. Global potential: Expands access to AI learning for students and developers in emerging economies, encouraging grassroots innovation worldwide.

The STEM Practice Company
Interactive AI platforms for STEM education, featuring hands-on simulations and personalised curricula. Global potential: Addresses educational gaps in under-resourced schools; scalable for global STEM equity initiatives.

Avinyaa EdTech (Creativespace)
Immersive AI-powered learning experiences and interactive edtech tools designed to increase student engagement. Global potential: Strengthens digital education outcomes across developing countries with infrastructure constraints. ● Sustainability
Clean Water Generator

AI-optimised atmospheric water generation and purification systems using sensors to produce clean water efficiently in water-scarce regions. Global potential: Highly relevant for arid regions in Africa, West Asia and South Asia; low-energy AI supports global water-access goals. Mankomb
AI-native kitchen appliance called Chewie, which converts wet waste, including bones and meat, into nutrient-rich soil within hours using real-time sensors. Global potential: Addresses household waste and soil health in urban and rural environments; promotes circular economy adoption worldwide. ● Multilingual access

Bolna AI
Multilingual voice AI for customer engagement, conversational agents and accessibility solutions. Global potential: Designed for linguistically diverse societies like India and applicable to multilingual regions in Africa and South-east Asia. Rootle Voconv
Voice conversion and synthesis technology enabling real-time translation, accessibility tools and multilingual content creation. Global potential: Reduces language barriers in education, media and customer service; valuable for diverse, low-literacy populations globally. Awaaz Labs
Voice AI focused on multilingual content generation, speech-to-text and audio processing tools. Global potential: Enables in-

clusive digital ecosystems in markets where English is not the dominant language. Sarvam AI
Full-stack generative AI platform with offline multilingual capabilities, including Kaze smart glasses for real-time visual and audio explanation and translation in local languages. Global potential: Offline edge AI supports low-connectivity regions; positions India as a leader in population-scale, inclusive AI solutions for the Global South. ● Global South use cases

Taiyo.AI
Vertical AI platform for construction and infrastructure, which aggregates global project data for tender analysis, risk intelligence, market forecasting and ESG benchmarking. Global potential: Enables architecture, engineering and construction (AEC) firms in emerging economies to plan sustainable infrastructure; datasets support urban development across Asia, Africa and Latin America amid rapid urbanisation. Invincible Ocean

Hybrid blockchain and AI platform for secure, compliant enterprise applications in regulated sectors, with custom models for data-intensive use cases such as mobility and video analytics. Global potential: Strengthens trust in AI-blockchain deployments for finance, logistics and governance in markets that prioritise transparency and data sovereignty. Wadhvani AI

Non-profit organisation building AI solutions for social impact, including tools for healthcare diagnostics, education personalisation and agricultural advisory in underserved communities. Global potential: Open-source models adaptable to low-resource environments worldwide, with demonstrated pilots in education and health across the Global South. If India is serious about turning moments like this into a movement, the next step is obvious: Take the summit off the usual circuit and into cities where ambition already exists but access does not. And if the occasional flourish of chaos accompanies the expansion, well... that may simply be proof that something genuinely alive is happening.

Shubho Sengupta is a digital marketer with an analogue past

FROM THE LABS.

Soil testing of rhizosphere

A new soil testing solution that can extract multiple nutrients simultaneously has been jointly developed by BARC Mumbai, GB Pant University of Agriculture, Pantnagar; and Indian Agricultural Research Institute, New Delhi, under a research project supported by the Board of Research in Nuclear Sciences. The technology has been patented and is expected to be useful to farmers, soil testing labs and the fertilizer industry.

The extractant is based on the understanding that plants absorb nutrients not from the bulk soil as a whole, but from the immediate zone around their roots — called the rhizosphere. Nutrient availability depends more on the chemical conditions in this root zone than on overall soil chemistry. For the first time, scientists have created a soil extractant that mimics this rhizospheric environment. It provides more accurate estimates of the nutrient available to plants — rather than just the nutrient in the soil. The formulation uses organic acids with low molecular weight, along with a chelating agent (EDTA), and a buffering compound called MES, adjusted to a pH of about 6. A non-ionic, water-soluble polymer is added to help particles settle (flocculation). Care has been taken to ensure that none of these chemicals interfere with the measurement of nutrients. Researchers also found that the method can be extended to estimate soil nitrogen, specifically ammonium and nitrate forms, when used alongside measurements of easily oxidisable organic carbon. The technique may further be adapted to assess pollutant elements such as nickel, cadmium, lead, chromium and arsenic.

Novel cathode material for aqueous zinc-ion batteries

Researchers have developed a novel cathode material that dramatically enhances the performance and stability of aqueous zinc-ion batteries.



Aqueous zinc-ion batteries, which use water-based electrolytes, are hailed as safe, cost-effective and environmentally benign contenders for storing energy from renewable sources like solar and wind. Zinc offers high theoretical capacity, abundant reserves and is used directly as the anode. However, the development of high-capacity, long-lasting cathode materials has been a key challenge.

Researchers at the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences (CeNS), Bengaluru, have “synthesised sulphur vacancy-induced 1T-phase molybdenum disulphide (1T-MoS₂), a material that promises to make zinc batteries more viable for largescale grid storage”, says a press release. The team comprising Ganesh Mahendra, Dr Rahuldeb Roy and Dr Ashutosh Kumar Singh used a carefully controlled hydrothermal method to produce sulphur deficient 1T-MoS₂ nanoflakes. This metallic-phase material possesses a high surface area and enhanced conductivity, which facilitates faster electrochemical reactions and greater charge storage. The study aimed to optimise the electrochemical potential window, the voltage range within which the battery operates stably. They identified 0.2 to 1.3 volts as the ideal operational window. The fabricated zinc-ion battery demonstrated cyclic stability, retaining 97.91 per cent of its initial capacity after 500 continuous charge-discharge cycles at a high current density. The device exhibited a coulombic efficiency of 99.7 per cent, indicating highly reversible zinc-ion insertion and extraction with minimal side reactions.

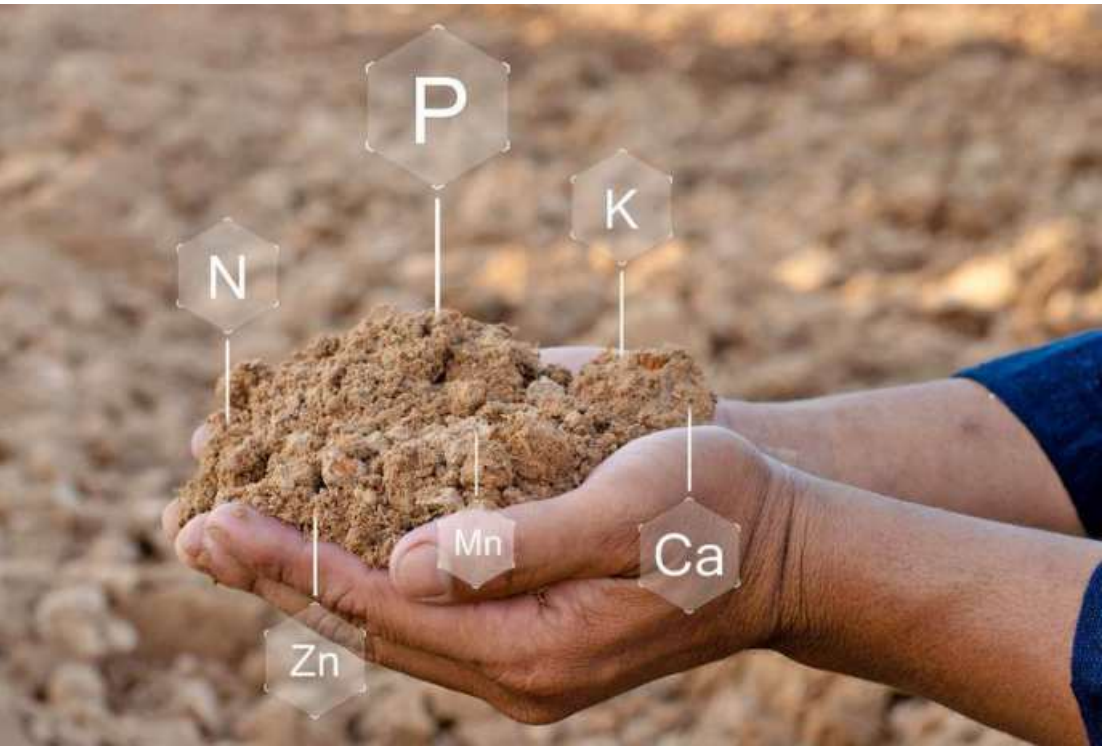
MARINE BIOPROSPECTING

How sea microbes can protect agri fields

FARMER’S DEEP-SEA FRIENDS. Research focuses on micro-denizens of the deep that can promote plant growth and stress resilience

K Bharat Kumar

Today, agriculture faces pressure from soil degradation and the climate crisis. Our oceans can serve as a large laboratory for solutions to help plants withstand such stresses. Marine biotechnology, which has contributed significantly to the pharmaceutical sector, has the potential to disrupt the fertilizer and pesticide markets. Prof Radhakrishnan Manikkam of the Centre for Drug Discovery and Development at Sathyabama Institute of Science and Technology says marine microbes hold promise in agricultural biotechnology. He has worked on isolating actinobacteria — the organisms responsible for numerous antibiotics — from environments that haven’t been fully explored, such as the deep sea. Unlike terrestrial microbes, the marine variants are adapted to survive highly saline environments, pressure and temperature, making them ideal catalysts for plant growth and stress resilience in crops. In a paper titled ‘Plant growth promoting properties of marine bacteria, actinobacteria and fungi’, published under the compilation ‘Marine microbiome and microbial bioprospecting’, Manikkam refers to innovations such as synthetic microbial communities, where compatible microbes are “rationally assembled, as opposed to using just one strain — for example, one strain promotes plant growth, another helps fight pathogens, while yet another is tailored to counter environmental pollution”. In a conversation with businessline, Manikkam says using microbes



LATE BLOOMER. Biofertilizers show return on investment only after sustained use over multiple seasons

extracted from nature helps preserve land fertility, unlike chemical fertilizers that harm the soil. He points out that microbes are used as fertilizers in Asian countries such as Thailand, China and Vietnam, where microbe-assisted organic farming systems are practised for high-value crops like durian and dates. Marine microorganisms support agriculture through several direct and indirect mechanisms. Marine microorganisms that promote plant growth act as natural biofertilizers. For instance, marine bacteria like *Bacillus subtilis* convert atmospheric nitrogen into ammonia, a form that plants can

easily absorb. The microbes also make nutrients available to plants by secreting organic acids that solubilise insoluble phosphates. They enhance the availability of calcium and magnesium in the soil. Moreover, sea microbes produce phytohormones, which assist in root development and shoot elongation. KEY TO SOIL HEALTH They protect crops indirectly by producing siderophores, which make iron unavailable to pathogens, and secreting enzymes that degrade the cell wall of fungal pests. Research shows that certain strains derived from oceans, such as *Pseudomonas fluorescens*, can help

suppress diseases such as wheat sheath blight. Compared to fast-acting chemicals, sea microbes work ‘slow but steady’ and help restore long-term soil health. M Gomathy, an Associate Professor at the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University (TNAU), says lack of awareness and hesitancy of end-users are major hurdles in the progress of bio-innovation. At an international conference on ‘Microbial biotechnology for sustainable development in environment and agriculture’ organised recently by Sathyabama Institute, Gomathy said biofertilizers improve soil biological activity and nutrient-use efficiency over time. On the other hand, long-

term intensive chemical use “may reduce soil organic carbon and microbial diversity”. Also, biofertilizers take longer to show return on investment, requiring sustained use over multiple seasons. She added that organic inputs release nutrients gradually through microbial activity, improving nutrient retention and supporting soil microorganisms. The long-term economic incentive is significant, she pointed out. When used consistently, biofertilizers can reduce chemical fertilizer requirement by 15-30 per cent in several cropping systems. Further, organic certified products often fetch premium prices. Despite the advantages, large-scale adoption remains a challenge. Though biofertilizers are supported under various government schemes that provide subsidies to small and medium farmers, usage is generally driven by ‘progressive and large farmers’ or village heads whose success with bio-agents, such as increased crop yields or latex yields in rubber estates, creates a ripple effect in the community. Gomathy highlighted her team’s contribution in developing a yeast-based microbial consortium to enhance rice yield, which is being readied for technology release via TNAU. “Ongoing work includes a high-density liquid arbuscular mycorrhizal fungal (AMF) inoculum developed via root organ culture, which achieved more than 2 lakh propagules per ml,” she said. The fungi enhance nutrient uptake, improve water-use efficiency and stress tolerance, and strengthen overall plant resilience.

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

WOW. Flaring and quaking



Team Quantum

Solar flares — bursts of energy from the sun — are known to disturb the earth’s upper atmosphere. They create beautiful auroras but also endanger satellites and power grids. Now, some scientists think they may also kick up earthquakes. When a flare is directed towards the earth, it disturbs the ionosphere — a high-altitude layer of the atmosphere filled with charged particles. These disturbances can (and do) influence electrical conditions deep below the earth’s surface, affecting geological faults — cracks in the earth’s crust, where earthquakes are born. The connection between solar flares and earthquakes is still a hypothesis, founded on

computer modelling. The reasoning goes like this: deep within the stressed rock fractures exist hot, pressurised water in a supercritical state (neither liquid nor gas). This water contains charged particles, allowing the cracks to store electrical energy — like a capacitor. The fractures, or faults, are also the zones where tectonic plates push against each other. Over time, mechanical stress builds up along them until it is released as an earthquake. If proven, this idea would suggest that “space weather” has a role in seismic activity. However, other scientists urge caution before nailing it down as the truth. They argue that the model used in the study is highly simplified and that the complex structure of the earth would likely weaken any such effect to the point of being negligible.

DEMOCRATISED DATA

Qualcomm has an Edge in India

Sindhu Hariharan

For true democratisation of AI and sustainability, you have to take AI to where data originates, says a senior executive at fabless chip design giant Qualcomm Technologies. “As data centres (DCs) roll out at large scale, the question to ask is, ‘Does it make sense to actually do all the processing in the DC or should we distribute the workload across the entire network?’” says Durga Malladi, EVP and GM (Technology Planning, Edge Solutions and Data Centre), Qualcomm Technologies. This narrative increasingly resonates with policymakers and enterprises, he adds. “With AI agents coming in, you don’t have to pick up your phone and do things. The idea is to simply use voice and you have an agent that breaks down any complicated task, run and tap into applications behind the scenes,” Malladi explains. Qualcomm supports



CHIPS PACKAGE. Durga Malladi, EVP and GM (Technology Planning, Edge Solutions and Data Centre), Qualcomm Technologies smartphones, PCs, automotive electronics and new-age tech, such as Meta’s Ray Ban glasses, with Edge AI. At the recent AI summit in New Delhi, the tech major announced that it is working closely with India’s sovereign AI startup Sarvam, whose models run on Qualcomm Snapdragon platforms. DEMAND FOR MEMORY However, alongside the bullishness on Edge AI, Qualcomm has resumed making silicon for DCs, chal-

lenging Nvidia’s domination in this segment. Its newly launched AI chips for DCs — AI200 and AI250 — are designed for improved memory capacity and running AI inference. “We have a deployment coming up in Saudi Arabia. We have also received tons of interest from local [Indian] DC players,” Malladi says. Qualcomm CEO Cristiano Amon had, in a recent earnings call, flagged an existing memory shortage, adding the company anticipates an early resolution. Malladi says a single DC rack has about 40 terabytes memory, so the requirement for the planned capacity rollouts dwarfs the original estimate. Qualcomm also announced it is partnering with Tata Electronics to manufacture Qualcomm automotive modules at the latter’s upcoming semiconductor assembly and test facility in Jalgroad, Assam. The modules can support digital cockpits, infotainment, connectivity and intelligent vehicle systems.

BOTS WILL BE BOTS

Why India should choose to build not just powerful, but also governable AI

Three protocols that can safe-keep democratic rights for a billion-strong people in the age of data mining

N Nagaraj

The India AI Impact Summit took place last week and, as India accelerates AI deployment at unprecedented scale, the critical question is not just about technical capability but also institutional capacity to govern algorithmic power. The choice is stark. India can build systems that are efficient but opaque, fast but unaccountable, and powerful but uncontrollable. Or we can build systems that are efficient and transparent, fast and accountable, and powerful and governable. If India demonstrates that democratic governance can work at the scale of a billion people in the age of AI, we provide proof of concept for the entire world. Here are three protocols that matter. Licence plates for AI agents Within two years, AI systems will routinely act on behalf of organisations and individuals, conducting transactions, filing returns, bidding on contracts. Who

authorises them? What are they permitted to do? How is that authority verified? India needs a protocol for AI agent identity, similar to how UPI handles payment authorisation. Every agent operates under a specific time-limited mandate — “This agent can submit procurement bids up to ₹5 lakh in defined categories for 90 days”. When the mandate expires, the agent stops. No auto-renewal. The system forces periodic human review. This is not surveillance. It is accountability infrastructure. Just as UPI verification is federated (banks verify mandates, not the government), AI agent verification would operate peer to peer. India has already built Aadhaar and UPI. We know how to create protocols that work at billion-person scale. The decision packet When a UPI payment fails, you receive an immediate error code: U30 for “Transaction declined by receiver’s bank”. Algorithmic decisions in governance need a similar infrastructure.



Every rejection must emit a ‘decision packet’ containing the outcome, the factors that drove it and, critically, a counterfactual explanation. Not “rejected because of income criteria” but “your declared income is ₹3 lakh; to qualify it must be under ₹2.5 lakh”. This gives citizens agency. They can identify data errors and take corrective action. Appeals must move at system speed. If an algorithm can reject in five seconds, the remedy can-

not take 30 days. Three tiers: Automated error correction in seconds; borderline cases reviewed in 24 to 48 hours; and contested decisions resolved in seven days or auto-approved. Statistical triparties auto-suspend systems when reversal rates (how often appeals succeed) exceed 5 per cent. The data becomes the regulator. This extends India’s RTI tradition into the algorithmic age: From the Right to Information to the Right to Understand.

The data passport A District Magistrate spends three years learning about his region: Groundwater patterns, migration cycles, why certain projects fail. Then they transfer. That knowledge walks out. Six months later, an AI system deploys with zero contextual knowledge and repeats solved mistakes. India needs protocols that enable institutional memory to compound rather than reset. Data passports work like international travel: Data stays with the ministry that collected it but can move for specific purposes under time-limited visas — “This data can travel to Ministry of Health for aggregate malnutrition analysis for 90 days.” Protocol guardians (data trusts) do not store data. They verify requests, stamp passports, maintain audit trails. Like immigration officers verify travellers but do not store their details. This is the best way to navigate Centre vs State vs local government data jurisdictions without changing the defined or

designed dynamics of those relationships. Helpful to navigate between departments and regulators and other bodies as well. INVISIBLE ARCHITECTURE But protocols alone are not enough. Infrastructure is useless if the people interacting with it cannot understand what they are seeing. Every technological revolution produces two types of infrastructure. First comes the visible: The fibre-optic cables, server farms. Then comes the invisible: The shared mental models that allow a society to govern the new power it has created. Citizens need to know that every automated rejection should come with a decision packet and that systems refusing to explain themselves are defective. Bureaucrats need to understand that when a vendor promises 99 per cent accuracy, the question is: “What was your reversal rate in pilots?” Journalists need to learn to read algorithmic dashboards the way financial re-

porters read balance sheets. Most critically, we must teach the next generation algorithmic civics. Not just coding, but also auditing the systems that govern their lives. Imagine a civics class where students not just read about the Constitution but actively audit a local scholarship algorithm or housing waitlist. They ask: “Who collected this data? Whose voices are missing? Where does optimisation hide bias?” INDIA’S ADVANTAGE We built the world’s largest identity layer. We built the world’s largest payments layer... without creating surveillance infrastructure. The question is whether we recognise AI governance as the same category of challenge. Whether we build authorisation, accountability and knowledge infrastructure, not eventually but now, while the choices are still being made... whether we will spend the 2030s governing algorithmic power or being governed by it?

GLOBAL BYTES.

Maersk orders eight China-made ships

AP Moller-Maersk has signed an order for eight large vessels with New Times Shipbuilding Co Ltd in China. All eight ships will have the same characteristics and make up a new series of

18,600 TEU vessels, with delivery scheduled in 2029 and 2030. At 366 m length and 58.6 m breadth, the vessels are more compact than the current maximum container vessel length of 400 m. The ships will be equipped with dual-fuel engines that can operate on conventional bunker fuel or liquefied gas.

Maersk currently has 33 vessels on order, with four scheduled for delivery this year, says a release.

‘Relook Schengen entry/exit system’

Airports Council International (ACI) Europe, Airlines for Europe (A4E) and International Air Transport Association (IATA) have warned that the Schengen entry/exit system (EES) continues to cause significant delays for passengers. In the absence of immediate action to provide sufficient flexibility, severe disruptions are likely over the peak summer months, with queues potentially involving four-hour waits or more.

In a letter to Magnus Brunner, EU Commissioner for Internal Affairs and Migration, airports and airlines, ACI said waiting times reached up to two hours at airport border control as the current stage of the EES progressive rollout mandated that 35 per cent of all third country nationals entering the Schengen zone must be registered. It urged the European Commission to confirm that Schengen member states will retain the ability to partially or totally suspend EES until end-October 2026.

Tracking urban connectivity capex

Funds released and/or utilised for metro rail projects between 2021-22 and 2025-26 (till Feb 5, 2026)



Metro rail project	Funds released (in ₹crore)
Delhi	16,976.86
Chennai	11,289.93
Bengaluru	17,488.74
Patna	1,627.31
Kolkata East and West corridor	634.53
Kochi	287.54
Mumbai Metro Line 3	13,373.72
Nagpur	1,274.06
Pune	6,081.08
Thane	150.00
Ahmedabad	5,146.43
Surat	6,955.71
Bhopal	2,211.92
Indore	2,461.6
Millennium City Centre to Cyber City Gurugram	130.00
Kanpur	4,960.50
Agra	3,467.68

Source: Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs

RE POSTS.

- ✕

Major step by Indian Railways towards Net zero carbon emmission!
Electrification of the IR’s Broad Gauge network has reached 99.4%, resulting in a 62% drop in diesel consumption and saving 178 crore litres in 2024-25 as compared to 2016-17. So far, 25 States have achieved 100% electrification.
Ministry of Railways
@RailMinIndia
- ✕

Precision on the Ground, Excellence in the Air!
AAI has commenced Phase-III reconstruction of a section of Secondary Runway 19R-01L at Kolkata Airport @aaiKolairport. This key infrastructure upgrade underscores our commitment to enhancing operational safety, improving efficiency, and building future-ready airside capacity.
As air traffic demand continues to rise, AAI remains dedicated to strengthening airport infrastructure that ensures seamless, secure, and sustainable aviation growth.
Airports Authority of India
@AAL_Official

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Feb 5	Feb 19	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,66,000	1,68,000	1.19
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,57,000	1,58,000	0.63
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,68,000	1,67,000	-0.60
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,93,000	1,92,000	-0.52
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,97,000	1,98,000	0.51
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,15,000	2,14,000	-0.47
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,21,000	2,20,000	-0.45
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,65,000	1,64,000	-0.61
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,63,000	1,62,000	-0.62
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,38,000	1,40,000	1.43
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,68,000	1,67,000	-0.60
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	1,99,000	1,98,000	-0.51
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	1,99,000	1,98,000	-0.51
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,10,000	2,11,000	0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,10,000	2,09,000	-0.48
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,39,000	1,37,000	-1.46
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,80,000	2,81,000	0.36
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,80,000	2,81,000	0.36
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,62,000	1,60,000	-1.25
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,51,000	1,52,000	0.66
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,45,000	1,46,000	0.68
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	94,000	96,000	2.08
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,57,000	1,58,000	0.63
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,52,000	1,50,000	-1.33
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,10,000	1,12,000	1.79
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	59,000	60,000	1.67
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	80,000	82,000	2.44
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	58,000	58,000	0.00

Figures in ₹

Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

● RIVERINE ECONOMY

‘Green’ growth on inland waterways

FLOW CHART. Govt lines up projects worth ₹1,500 crore to unlock commercial potential of eco-friendly water transport

V Sajeev Kumar

Aimed at accelerating green mobility, strengthening multi-modal logistics and promoting river-led economic development, the Inland Waterways Development Council (IWDC) has unveiled a comprehensive roadmap to expand the country’s inland water transport network, facilitate major infrastructure investments and enhance Centre-State co-ordination to unlock the full economic potential of domestic river systems.

The IWDC 3.0 meeting, held recently in Kochi, identified projects worth more than ₹1,500 crore; foundation stones were laid for projects worth more than ₹150 crore, including river cruise jetties in Kerala, Gujarat, Karnataka, Odisha and Telangana, to expand cruise tourism circuits across the country.

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal said inland waterways are emerging as a powerful multiplier of green growth, digital transformation and tourism-led development. With the rapid expansion in cargo movement, passenger services and cruise tourism, the country’s rivers are becoming engines of sustainable mobility and economic opportunity.

IWDC is entrusted with the development of inland water transport, cargo movement and river tourism in the country. The council seeks to boost the economic potential of riverine transport and enhance infrastructure in a sustainable, eco-friendly manner.

Major new projects worth over ₹900 crore include the development of a slipway facility in Kochi, construction of 110 jetties across Odisha (25) and the North-East (85), and implementation of the National River Traffic and Navigation System (NRTNS) in Maharashtra.

According to officials, the development of 85 jetties on an investment of ₹500 crore will significantly strengthen connectivity, integrate regional logistics and create livelihood opportunities for riverine communities in the North-East. For Assam, the council has earmarked the ₹70 crore cruise terminal at Uzan Bazar Ghat in Guwahati and a ₹144 crore road connectivity project for the Bogibeel



NETWORKING THE NORTH-EAST. The inland water transport terminal at Jogighopa in Bongaigaon district, Assam

river port in Dibrugarh on the Brahmaputra (NW-2).

The council also noted the efforts of the Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI) towards conducting a feasibility study for urban water transport in 18 cities, including Guwahati, Varanasi, Patna, Tezpur and Dibrugarh.

BACKWATER NETWORK

Kerala’s vast backwater and canal network was highlighted as a major opportunity for inland waterways development. The State emerged as a key focus area at IWDC 3.0 with a series of major announcements to strengthen inland water transport and logistics.

A decision was made to implement the Jal Vahak cargo promotion scheme in Kerala, offering reimbursement of up to 35 per cent of the total operating expenditure incurred on cargo movement through inland waterways. The scheme is expected to encourage private sector participation by enabling cargo owners to hire vessels operated by entities other than the government bodies IWAI and

the Inland and Coastal Shipping Ltd (ICSL), making it particularly attractive for major shipping companies, freight forwarders, trade bodies and operators handling bulk and containerised cargo. Valid initially for three years, the initiative will help optimise supply chain networks and the commercial viability of water-based logistics.

The meeting highlighted the fact that cargo movement on national waterways had increased from 18 million tonnes in 2013-14 to 145.84 million tonnes in 2024-25, while the number of operational national waterways has grown 10-fold from three to 32.

The number of luxury river cruise vessels has increased from five to 25, reflecting growing confidence in the industry, and among investors and State governments. The number of operational terminals has increased from 15 to 25, and floating jetties from 30 to 100.

FAST-TRACK EXECUTION

With 111 national waterways spread across 23 States and four Union Territor-

ies, inland waterways are increasingly supporting initiatives such as Ro-Ro (roll-on, roll-off) vehicle movement and cruise tourism.

IWAI Chairperson Sunil Paliwal said IWDC 3.0 builds on the momentum generated by previous council meetings in Kolkata and Kaziranga (Assam). “It reinforces our resolve to fast-track execution of projects through close coordination with States and the adoption of clean, hybrid and smart digital systems,” he said.

The meeting concluded with a shared commitment by the Centre and States to scale up inland water transport, strengthen regional connectivity, promote cleaner transport solutions and position rivers as engines of economic growth. It reaffirmed inland waterways as a future-ready mode of transport for both cargo and passengers, contributing to cleaner transport, smarter logistics and a stronger India.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

● PREDICTIVE TOOLS

Data-driven orchestration of Indian Railways’ operations



LALIT CHANDRA TRIVEDI

Indian Railways is often described as the backbone of the country’s economy. But it would be more accurate to describe it as one of the most complex operating systems in the world.

Passenger and freight trains share the same network. Demand is never static. Seasonal passenger surges, fluctuating freight requirements, defence movements, disaster relief operations, port evacuation pressures and energy security commitments all compete for finite network capacity — often simultaneously.

This complexity is managed through two large digital platforms: the Freight Operations Information System (FOIS); and the Control Office Information System (COIS). Together, they generate enormous volumes of operational data each day. Yet, much of the decision-making still relies on human judgment under deadline pressure, supported by rule-based prioritisation and experience.

This is where artificial intelligence has the potential to fundamentally change outcomes.

Why is the current model under strain?

The existing operating model is largely reactive. When congestion builds up, when terminals choke or when coal stocks fall to critical levels, corrective actions are taken. While this has worked reasonably well for decades, the system is increasingly stretched due to several factors: The rapid growth in passenger volumes, especially during festival and exam seasons; rising coal demand for thermal power plants; growth in containerised and express freight; interface complexities between dedicated freight corridors (DFCC) and the conventional network; and climate-linked disruptions, such as floods and heat-related infrastructure stress.

In such circumstances, manual prioritisation becomes both risky and inefficient.



SEASONAL SURGE. Passenger demand is strongly influenced by holidays, regional events and weather patterns V RAJU

AI’s role in the Railways is not to replace controllers or operating officers but augmenting them — much like an invisible conductor guiding a large orchestra.

● Dynamic traffic prioritisation: AI models can continuously evaluate thousands of variables — train type, commodity criticality, passenger impact, power plant stock levels, defence requirements — and recommend optimal path allocations in real time.

● Predictive congestion management: By analysing historical FOIS and COIS data, AI can forecast yard congestion, siding detentions, crew shortages and terminal overloads hours or even days in advance, enabling preventive interventions instead of crisis management.

● Festival and peak-season demand forecasting: Passenger demand is strongly influenced by holidays, regional events and weather patterns. AI models trained on datasets can predict demand surges well in advance, enabling proactive rake planning and timetable adjustments.

● Coal and power sector assurance: AI can continuously match power plant coal stocks with generation demand and network health, dynamically reallocating rakes to avoid critical shortages and last-minute firefighting.

● Real-time disruption response: In the event of floods, accidents or signalling and/or overhead electri-

fication (OHE) failures, AI can instantly simulate multiple recovery scenarios — re-routing options, crew redeployment and restoration sequences — helping decision-makers choose the least disruptive path.

● DFCC and conventional network synchronisation: The full benefit of DFCCs depends on smooth handovers. AI can optimise interchange points to prevent spill-back congestion and maximise corridor throughput.

REAL TRANSFORMATION

The most important shift is not technological but cultural — from manual prioritisation to data-driven orchestration, from reactive firefighting to predictive operations, and from experience-only decisions to AI-augmented judgment.

The Indian Railways already possesses the data, scale and operational depth needed to deploy AI meaningfully. The challenge is to integrate intelligence across silos and empower frontline decision-makers with predictive tools.

If implemented thoughtfully, AI can help transform the Indian Railways from a system that copes with complexity into one that anticipates and masters it — quietly, continuously and at national scale.

The writer is a former General Manager of the Indian Railways

● RAILWAY UPKEEP.

Texmaco, RVNL biz tie-up gets rolling



ON TRACK. Texmaco is India’s largest wagon maker

Mithun Dasgupta

Backed by its joint-venture partnership with State-run Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd, Texmaco Rail & Engineering is entering into the rolling stock maintenance and infrastructure development business in the domestic market.

The company, currently India’s largest wagon maker and exporter of rolling stock, is also gearing up to compete with global majors in Europe, Africa and West Asia.

Under their joint venture shareholders’ agreement, Texmaco Rail and RVNL have created a platform to deliver integrated rail solutions to both domestic and international customers.

The partnership is structured to leverage public-sector execution depth with private sector manufacturing agility; Texmaco holds 49 per cent stake and RVNL retains majority ownership.

“The demand for maintenance or lifecycle support of rolling stocks is opening up in India. The partnership provides opportunities for Texmaco to collaborate in the maintenance of rolling stock like passenger trains, Vande Bharat, metro and locomotives. For the next-generation high-speed rails, PSU companies are expected to have a critical role including, in some cases, developing infrastructure, as they would be high-value IP (intellectual property) works. RVNL was also eager to have a railway partner they consider the best in the country, to support them in these works,” says Sudipta Mukherjee, Managing Director, Texmaco Rail & Engineering.

The Kolkata-headquartered company supplies rolling stock globally and has also ventured into the maintenance business in overseas markets.

“The collaboration (with RVNL) will help us build scale and qualify us in larger projects globally,” Mukherjee says.

Texmaco also eyes the locomotive business, which has so far remained an exclusive domain.

“We want to make not only loco shells, but also components and maintain them. It is a huge opportunity for us. We are delighted to partner with RVNL and work for *amanirbhar* Bharat, and are looking for more world-class Make-in-India products and services for the global stage,” the MD says.

This is not a tender-specific partnership, but meant to grow new lines of business. “It has a compounding effect. We will leverage our respective areas of strength and work on many innovative rail solutions for domestic as well as international markets,” he says.

MY FIVE.

SHEETAL ARORA
Promoter and Chief Executive
Officer, Mankind Pharma



Aloe vera, consistent workouts,
ashwagandha and magnesium

- Aloe vera:** Up at 6.30 am, I start my morning with two glasses of water with aloe vera. It's a habit I've stayed loyal to because it creates a calm, predictable start before the day gets demanding. I avoid jumping straight into screens or conversations. That short window of quiet helps organise my thoughts to approach the day with intention rather than urgency.
- Consistency:** Workouts are largely strength-led, weights, functional movements, a short stretch of cardio and yoga. Strength training builds endurance, while yoga supports flexibility, breathing and mental balance. Consistency matters over intensity. Wearing the WHOOP band (wearable fitness tracker) earlier this year sharpened my awareness of how these small rituals affect recovery, stress levels and daily readiness.
- Clean eating:** Breakfast is usually eggs or chila with coffee. Lunch stays light, mostly salads, and dinner is intentionally uncomplicated — often soup and chicken. I don't follow food trends or extreme diets. Clean eating is about clarity and energy, not restriction. My one indulgence — a square of 70 per cent dark chocolate after dinner.
- Disconnect, not disengage:** I follow cricket closely — strategies, leadership calls and shifts in momentum. Helps disconnect from work without disengaging my mind. There's much to learn from the patience the game demands.
- Ashwagandha, magnesium:** To unwind, I include magnesium and ashwagandha in my night diet, after a long stressful day. Ashwagandha helps deal with stress, calms the nervous system. Magnesium acts as a muscle relaxant to ensure improved sleep.

CAPSULE.

Cataract care on war footing

Millions of people living with cataract need access to a simple, sight-restoring surgery — one of the most effective and affordable



interventions to prevent avoidable blindness, the World Health Organization said, urging countries to accelerate efforts in this direction.

Cataract — the clouding of the eye's lens, which causes blurred vision and could lead to blindness — affects more than 94 million people globally. A 15-minute, cost-effective cataract surgery provides immediate and lasting restoration of sight, the WHO said.

Over two decades, global coverage of cataract surgery has increased by about 15 per cent, even as ageing populations and rising cataract cases have increased overall demand. The latest modelling predicts an 8.4 per cent rise in coverage for cataract surgery this decade. However, progress needs to accelerate sharply to meet the World Health Assembly target of 30 per cent increase by 2030, the WHO said.

COMING UP.

Quality meet for pharma cos

The two-day 11th Global Pharmaceutical Quality Summit, organised by the Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance, kicks off today in Mumbai. The industry conclave will be attended by drug regulatory representatives from multiple countries. There will be sessions on new technologies, AI and cross-industry insights. The meet comes at a time when US tariffs continue to cast a shadow of uncertainty over exports.

DIGITAL ADDICTION

The elephant in the room

CYBER MENACE. Concerns grow as connectivity strains mental wellbeing and cognitive development

KV Kurmanath

With nearly 970 million internet connections and a digital economy projected to contribute over 13 per cent of national income, the India story is, to a great extent, one of triumphant connectivity. Yet, a dark, unhealthy trend emerges from behind the glowing screens of the country's youth, prompting the government to flag a new behavioural crisis.

The Economic Survey 2026 had said in no uncertain terms that while internet access is no longer a constraint, the “intensely digital environment” was beginning to erode human capital through sleep debt, reduced productivity and mental health struggles.

By flagging ‘digital addiction’ as a threat to human capital, the survey, in fact, validated the fears of doctors and teachers who have watched with concern the smartphone morphing from a classroom nuisance to an existential crisis affecting health, learning and development.

Countries like Australia, France, Spain and China are taking affirmative actions to protect children from social media or gaming addictions. And the World Health Organization (WHO) has labelled online gaming addiction as a mental health condition.

At the recently concluded AI Impact Summit 2026, too, Union Minister for Electronics and Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnav said the Centre was talking to social media platforms on restricting access based on age.

This, he said, was important to protect children online, and address deepfakes.

“While obesity and inadequate nutrition threaten the physical health of youth, digital addiction undermines their cognitive and social development. Together, these interconnected challenges necessitate policies to safeguard



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the health and human capital of the next generation,” the Economic Survey noted.

Compulsive digital use is linked to anxiety, stress, depression and sleep disturbances, especially among students facing academic pressure and exposure to cyberbullying and high-stimulus platforms, it added.

HELPING TO DISCONNECT

The challenge is no longer about getting people online, but helping them disconnect.

As the government rolls out initiatives like the ‘Tele-MANAS’ helpline and ‘Digital Detox’ centres to combat this modern impulse control disorder, experts warn that the root cause runs deeper than just technology.

U Vindhya, former Professor of psychology at Tata Institute of Social Sciences, points out that the surge in digital addiction, with India already outpacing some Western nations, is causing a shift from a socially connected culture to one of isolation and loneliness.

“Excessive use resulting in addiction is an impulse control disorder, characterised by preoccupations, poorly controlled urges or behaviours, which lead to distress or impairment of functioning,” she points out.

Mapping the challenges stemming from digital addiction, the Economic Survey pointed out that the bulk of the victims were found to be in the 15-24 age group.

Jonathan N Bertrand, Founder and CEO of the US-based Social Media Research Institute, argues that while regulation provides necessary boundaries, it fails to address the immediate reality of user experience.

He called for ‘social media first aid’ (SMFA) — a framework that treats digital exposure as a public health priority by building user resilience rather than relying solely on bans.

“While lawsuits generally focus on accountability after the harm occurs, SMHR (social media harm reduction) focuses on prevention by equipping users, educators and institutions with SMFA. This addresses social media harm by providing individuals with the skills to understand platform architecture, behavioural triggers and online risks,” he says.

SOCIAL INTERACTIONS

Shashidhar Nanjundaiah, a veteran media educator, feels there's too much excitement in India over technology and not

enough guardrails.

He says education is one of the most affected areas because digital and AI technologies essentially compel us to outsource the learning process.

As education is precisely positioned to enable learning, it faces an existential crisis, albeit temporarily.

“In my experience, many students carry only their mobile phones to the classroom, and we end up insisting on note-taking. Small experiments to ban phones in classrooms are underway, and students seem to like the idea. The ability to listen and respond improved when the ban was applied,” he says.

PARENTAL REGULATION

Vindhya says there is no easy fix for this complex problem; there is a need for responsible parental regulation, rather than coercive measures.

Community groups and neighbourhood associations, too, should promote offline social interactions to foster social cohesion, belonging and social and communication skills. These will help prevent people from turning to the internet as a remedy for their feelings of isolation and loneliness.

FROM THE REGULATOR

UK medical device testing hits a high

UK patients could be among the first in the world to benefit from breakthrough medical devices, as clinical investigations peak in 2025.

New figures from the Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency (MHRA) show a 17 per cent rise in approved clinical investigations compared with last year, as companies increasingly choose Great Britain to test cutting-edge health technologies. At the same time, the MHRA is rolling out new measures to back innovation and remove barriers for smaller companies, including a fee waiver pilot, early market access for promising devices, and enhanced support for high-impact technologies.

For patients, this means quicker access to potentially life-changing technologies. For the NHS, it offers improved tools to diagnose disease, manage long-term illness and deliver more precise treatment.

The growth reflects a global race to tackle some of the most challenging health conditions. Dementia, Parkinson's disease and epilepsy are driving huge investments in neurotechnology, with studies in this area doubling since 2024 to make up around a quarter of all UK applications. Recent approvals include a feasibility study exploring whether deep brain stimulation can help treat addiction disorders and first-in-human paediatric research — led by Great Ormond Street Hospital (University College London) and the University of Oxford — on a rechargeable brain stimulation device designed to reduce seizure frequency in children with epilepsy.

AI-powered medical devices are surging in number, including tools that scan medical images to spot disease earlier and guide treatment decisions. New studies include digital tools that adjust treatment in real time, such as an app to help people with chronic obstructive pulmonary disease manage their condition. Studies in advanced eye-care technologies have increased as companies test new ways to protect vision and restore sight.

Companies are looking for speed, certainty and expertise. The MHRA has met 100 per cent of its statutory deadlines for clinical investigation applications since September 2023, with average approval time in 2025 at 51 days — nine days earlier than the 60-day target. Researchers receive hands-on scientific support, including specialist advice meetings, to design safer, more robust studies.

Source: MHRA



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Sending medicines via the
India-US trade corridor

BY INVITATION



NAMIT JOSHI

The India-US trade agreement is crucial because it's not just about improving economic ties but also creating resilient medicine supply chains. As global healthcare faces increasing pressure, especially over access to medicines, the strengthening of trade relations creates opportunities for both India and the US.

India is a leader in pharmaceutical manufacturing, known for producing high-quality generic medicines that treat various diseases at lower costs than branded medicines. With the largest number of manufacturing sites approved by the US Food and Drug Administration outside the US, India plays a crucial role in global pharmaceutical supply chains. The trade agreement with the US enhances access to one of the world's largest pharmaceutical markets.

Pharmaceutical exports to the US from India have increased by 20.43 per cent — from \$8.73 billion in FY2023-24 to \$10.52 billion in FY2024-25. The growth reflects India's importance in global pharmaceutical markets, especially the US, as a reliable and cost-effective supplier.

India's regulatory performance further solidifies its position in the US market. In 2025, the highest number of abbreviated new drug applications (ANDAs) went to India-based companies, which accounted for 46.6 per cent of the granted approvals (full and tentative). This highlights India's cost advantages, regulatory compliance, and expertise in generic drug development and manufacturing.

AVERTING SUPPLY DISRUPTION

The Covid-19 pandemic exposed vulnerabilities in global pharmaceutical supply chains, especially for critical medicines in countries like the US, thereby underscoring the importance of reliable, diversified supply chains. India's manufacturing capabilities helped mitigate shortages, and the trade deal ensures future disruption



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tions would be less likely, fostering a stable supply chain.

The trade agreement also enhances regulatory cooperation between the two countries, streamlining the drug approval process and reducing the time and cost associated with bringing drugs to market. This ensures faster delivery of essential medicines to patients.

The recent tariff changes and trade announcements have, however, affected the growth rate. While India's pharmaceutical exports to the US grew 20.43 per cent in FY2023-24, it was a modest 0.31 per cent increase in the first half of FY2025-26 (valued at about \$7.12 billion). The slowdown indicates that the tariff changes and policy fluctuations have created uncertainty.

However, with the trade agreement in place, there is strong optimism that growth will return to double digits in the coming years, ensuring India's continued role as a key supplier to the US.

By ensuring the continued supply of affordable generics and biosimilars, the India-US trade deal helps address global healthcare challenges and reduce the cost of essential medicines. It is a key step towards a more sustainable global healthcare system, strengthening pharmaceutical supply chains and promoting regulatory cooperation.

While the agreement offers clear benefits, the recent slowdown in growth also highlights the complexities of global trade. But a partnership between the two countries has the potential to boost both economies.

The writer is Chairman, Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council of India. Views are personal

Where a hospital grew from the people

J Mangaiyarkarasi

Away from the limelight, a community-led hospital in Tamil Nadu's Nilgiris district has been screening the region's tribal residents, one hamlet at a time.

Standing tall in the misty Gudalur valley, the Gudalur Adivasi Hospital has been steadily building a sustainable healthcare model for tribal communities battling sickle cell anaemia, tuberculosis and malnutrition, among other illnesses, in a region once beset by poor access to care and preventable deaths. The hospital is managed by a registered charitable society, Association for Health Welfare in the Nilgiris (ASHWINI), formed by the indigenous tribal communities.

“In 1988, the community work started, but we were sending people to Gudalur general hospital (about 2 km away) for hospitalisations,” says family medicine specialist Dr Mrudula Rao, who's been with the



COMMUNITY-LED CARE. Gudalur Adivasi Hospital, run by ASHWINI charitable society, in Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu J MANGAIYARKARASI

adivasi hospital for more than 20 years. “Back then, the tribals faced discrimination. They were kept out of a lot of places, and that sometimes included hospitals as well,” she says.

This led to training community members to provide care and, eventually, the hospital was born.

One of the early trainees — the shy and amiable obstetrician's assistant Ambika — now helps run the hospital after years of experience in deliver-

ies and mentoring younger doctors, says Dr Rao.

DOORSTEP CARE

Today, nearly 75 per cent of the hospital staff — nurses, counsellors, field workers and ‘health animators’ — belong to local tribal communities. The training programme, too, has evolved into a formal nursing school, adjacent to the hospital. The staff members track pregnancies, illnesses, deliver medicines and conduct health

follow-ups across 320 hamlets in the Gudalur and Pandalur taluks. The hospital's eight decentralised units offer regular monitoring and mental health counselling services at the patient's doorstep.

The community-led approach has built trust over the years among the locals, who are otherwise too shy to seek care, says Dr Nandakumar Menon, Co-founder of the hospital. Institutional deliveries and antenatal coverage, once near absent, are now almost universal in their catchment.

Newborn screening, specifically for sickle cell anaemia, began in 2011, alongside providing preventive prophylactic penicillin to young children and hydroxyurea treatment for sickle cell anaemia. And the results show.

“We have not had any deaths between ages zero and five (out of nearly 350 deliveries a year),” Dr Menon says, noting that infant mortality in the region historically stood at around 250 per 1,000 live

births until some years ago.

The 50-bed hospital has grown into a secondary-care facility with general inpatient and outpatient services, ultrasound and X-ray units, two operating theatres, a laparoscopic surgery unit, a blood bank and a high-dependency unit (ICU equivalent).

PERSISTENT GAPS

But challenges remain. The median age of death among adults with sickle cell anaemia remains 25, which is 30 years lower than that of non-sickle disease aboriginal population, says Dr Menon. Advanced treatments like bone marrow transplant for sickle cell anaemia remain inaccessible for most families in this region, as poverty and lack of awareness still shape healthcare outcomes in Gudalur, in ways medicine alone cannot fix.

The writer is a fellow covering rare diseases under the National Press Foundation's 2025 Rare Diseases Reporting Fellowship

BIG CHALLENGE. Scriptures that don't exist being created, cautions AI Summit attendee

The just-concluded India AI Impact Summit brought together heads of state, policymakers and technology leaders to debate the future of artificial intelligence (AI). But alongside geopolitical strategy and semiconductor supply chains, a more existential concern surfaced — the integrity of faith in the age of AI.

Singh said he tested a GPT application marketed around Sikh teachings using prompts related to Gurbani, the verses and teachings of the Sikh gurus, and found that it generated lines presented as scripture that



"AI is here to stay for long. Religious traditions now confront an unexamined question — what becomes of transcendence when the sacred is delivered through a subscription bot? This was not a matter of visual manipulation or deepfakes. The system was producing scriptural lines that simply do not exist," he told *businessline* on the sidelines of the summit.

tion. A sub-committee comprising technical experts was recently constituted by advocate Harjinder Singh Dharmi, President of Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), at its headquarters in Amritsar, to examine the growing misuse of AI in matters related to Sikh scripture and history.

"I was part of the meeting. The committee has been formed to curb the growing trend of spreading misinformation about Sikhism through AI technology, and

to prevent the circulation of content on social media that undermines the dignity and sanctity of the Sikh faith,” said Singh.

According to him, a key concern is that foundational AI models developed by major technology firms are not adequately trained on authentic Sikh scriptures and related materials.

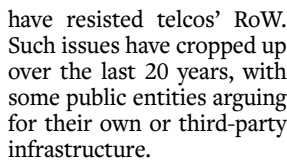
"That's something which is of profound concern. I don't think it is a matter of concern only for the Sikh community but for any religion in general," he said, warning that fabricated scriptural content could easily be mistaken for authentic text by those unfamiliar with original sources.

Singh added that AI experts from the UK and the US are part of the SGPC's advisory panel.

Sarabjot Singh, an AI researcher and educator, formerly with the University of Warwick, also addressed a session at the summit.

The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has directed the Noida airport authorities to allow telecom companies to set up mobile network infrastructure, recognising the airport as a public entity. This comes shortly after the government instructed the Navi Mumbai airport authorities to do the same.

“It is clarified that, in terms of the Telecommunications Act, 2023, Noida International Airport qualifies as a public entity for the purpose of the said Act and the rules framed thereunder. Accordingly, the obligations



The Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI) has also written to DoT regarding the difficulties faced by licensed telecom service providers (TSPs) in establishing telecom infrastructure as authorities asked TSPs to use in-building telecom network at charges deemed unreasonably high.

In its latest order, the DoT said the Telecommunications Act, 2023, read with the Telecommunications (Right of Way) Rules, 2024,

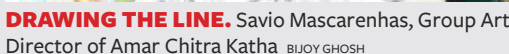
provides a statutory framework for grant of RoW permissions to licensed TSPs for establishment, operation and maintenance of telecommunication networks.

“The provisions mandate non-discriminatory, fair and transparent processing of RoW applications within the prescribed timelines and conditions,” it said.

The COAI had also asked the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India to cap costs for in-building telecom infrastructure in public spaces, stating that cost-based price ceilings help avoid rent-seeking behaviour, delays in network rollout and direct consumer harm, especially when a single entity controls the access to an essential service.

AI destroys the style and soul of artistic labour, lament artists at Comic Con

Remember how last year social media timelines were flooded with people posting their wide-eyed cutesy images in the distinctive style of Japanese animation house Studio Ghibli, recreated by ChatGPT.



Chitra Katha, said he believes that while AI can produce significantly higher volumes of content faster and cheaper, it lacks the essence of hand-crafted work. “The individuality that each artist brings in terms of style and the stories that they tell, AI cannot recreate that,” he said.

Beyond just stylistic concerns, comics are often a labour of years with multiple iterations before the page reaches print. Rajesh Nagu-

lakonda, an independent comic artist, said he believes comics or any art form usually reflects a journey or a culmination of a vision built and nurtured over a long time. "It is impossible to commodify that process," he said.

Not all technologies are necessarily bad, he added. "When we went from drawing on paper to drawing digitally, it made things a lot easier. But that is not the same as generating content

with no human effort. Similarly, AI might also have its place in fringe cases, but the process of comic-making itself should continue to be human," he said.

Artists also perceive a dip in terms of the quality of work itself because of cheap and easy AI-generated content.

Ron Marx, known for his work on titles such as *Batman, Aliens* and *Green Lantern*, said that when you look at something generated by AI, there is a sense that something is missing.

"There is that uncanny valley that I think we have conquered in CGI and other digital effects, which still feels very present in AI. I would rather have something imperfect that was made by a person than something that tries to be perfect, that is just culled from everything else," he said.

India's biggest FMCG advertisers pulled back their ad expenditure in the December quarter, squeezing the ad revenues of entertainment platforms.

Companies such as Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL), Procter & Gamble (P&G), Marico and Colgate-Palmolive reported reduced ad spends of 6 per cent, 17 per cent, 2 per cent and 8 per cent.

While Dabur was the only one to slightly increase spends by 1.9 per cent, the overall ad spends were

Ad spend			
	in ₹ (cr)		
Companies	Q3FY26	Q2FY26	Q3FY25
Colgate	206.84	225.10	200.10
Dabur	238.02	233.57	226.72
Marico	336.00	345.00	296.00
P&G	145.48	175.97	158.34
HUL	1,522.00	1,632.00	1,486.00

mented. The impact of this was felt by companies such as Zee Entertainment, which reported lower ad revenues of 9 per cent annually and a 10 per cent decline in domestic advertising revenue annually due to the slowdown in FMCG spending.

Similarly, JioStar said the TV ad market remains chal-

challenging due to spend cuts by FMCG and consumer electronics.

“GST benefits rolled out last quarter gave a boost to durables and auto sector. While FMCG was busy planning for premiumisation, the GST rollout and Trump tariffs had them in a tight spot. They had to rethink premium products and go back to mass products and focus on tier-2 markets. Hence, the pause on ad spends,” Ajimon Francis, MD, Brand Finance India, *told businessline*.

Despite the soft performance by brands in the last

quarter, Francis anticipates growth in ad spends during Holi as summer products begin their campaigns following the extended winter.

Niranjan Gupta, CFO, Executive Director, Finance, HUL, said during the last earnings call: "When you look at the 9-month of this fiscal, our A&P to percentage revenue is 10 per cent, the same as previous year. On an absolute basis, our A&P has gone up by ₹200 crore. If you combine that we are buying efficiencies, in effective terms, it's gone up even more. As we move forward, we will continue to invest behind brand and there would be that step up."

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